Farewell, Rayashki

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Welcoming Ceremony

FR-01

???: I once traveled to a small town called Rayashki.

???: It was located high up within the Arctic Circle, and it was frigid cold all year long.

???: After my visit there, I traveled to many more places, from Zealand to the Balkan Peninsula. My journey went on and on.

???: But above all other places, I kept finding my thoughts returning to that little town. To its incandescent lights glowing in the long dark of the polar night, to the shared dream of the people there.

???: I got this picture book from Rayashki.

It is a children's book—a thin one at that. But, story inside has the power to warm a frigid heart.

Once opened, whirls of bright primary colors run into one another and flow up onto my palm.

I found myself returning to it during stormy days when I was stuck at home.

This is a story about honest and ordinary people.

Rayashki

???: The swans are dancing in a circle. Their arms go back and forth!

???: Vila and the swans have done this dance almost twenty times last week. She taught the swans all their beautiful moves.

???: "Swan Lake is the best ballet ever," I remembered Mr. Evgeni once said so. He also said the tortoises would come to watch the show. But why would tortoises want to watch Swan Lake?

???: Vila says she doesn't like the tortoises. She likes "knowledge." I don't know much about knowledge, but I think Ms. Vila is always right.

???: Only between you and me—Vila smells like seaweed and coral. But those are "happy" smells to me. I think she must be the princess of the ocean.

???: But she tells us she is not special and that everyone here is equal, no matter if they are a princess or a swan!

???: That we all have two feet and ten fingers, and if we all work together, we can "build a beacon to the future." I hope in the future we still get to sing and dance, when we are not building beacons.

???: Nina's favorite food is called Alenka; it's a chocolate bar. She used to cry a lot whenever she made a mistake with her dancing, but then Vila talked to her, and now she doesn't cry so much.

???: One time, she danced very, very perfectly, so Vila gave her a piece of an Alenka bar.

???: I believe she will be a great dancer—if she doesn't get too nervous on stage, then she could have even more chocolate!

???: I wish I was like her. I want chocolate too!

???: But I'm not a swan like her. And now there's never any Alenka in the canteen's cupboard.

???: Now, Nina is the swan princess—the most prettiest of all swans.

???: Pasono is the swan prince. He is a nice swan, and he has many many swan friends.

???: And Pyotr is the evil sorcerer, a black swan. Nobody wanted to be the bad guy, but Pyotr doesn't mind.

???: He is very serious and always bossy to everyone, so he doesn't have many swan friends.

???: Pyotr just wants to do his job as perfectly as he can, because he loves our town.

Avgust: Now Avgust is not a swan, but he also loves his town.

Avgust: *sniffs*

Avgust: Then there is the little mouse, who moves as quickly as the blowing wind.

Avgust: Will it be our new visitor?!

Avgust: What was it that Vila said about new visitors? I don't remember now.

Avgust puts down his paper, returning to the world of noise and people.

He looks around for a familiar face.

Avgust: Vila!

The boy slips through the crowd. Until at last he finds that face, looking out over a snowy field.

Vila: Mm?

Avgust: Reporting to you, Comrade Vila! I have a very important question!

Vila: Well, then go ahead, little Comrade Avgust.

Avgust: How should we receive the new visitors coming to town?

Avgust: Maybe we can welcome them with Alenka, or friendship, or maybe something else?

Vila: *chuckles*

Vila: We will welcome them with white snow, with smiles on our faces, and with the welcoming arms we use to achieve our dreams. As we do for everyone who comes here, little comrade.

Vila wipes away the paint from the child's face and stands.

Vila: It's always good to ask questions. But don't forget your task today, alright?

She points to the unfinished painting in his hand.

Avgust nods eagerly.

Avgust: I won't!

Avgust: My drawings are important, but Vila says entertaining our new friends is also important. Which one comes first?

He holds up his cluttered drawing board.

Avgust: After the swans have flown away, Evgeni will go up to the stage.

Avgust: Evgeni is not an evil sorcerer, but he knows a secret magic that makes everyone's tongues hide in their mouths.

Avgust: He is not so much a bad person, I think. Evgeni's shadow is very long, but no one, not even my sunflower, can explain why.

Avgust: Evgeni walks heavily onto the stage; his appearance comes without any applause.

The tall figure reaches the podium.

Evgeni: *clears throat*

Evgeni: We have received a telegraph. Zeno's investigators will arrive here in Rayashki tomorrow afternoon.

Evgeni: And we will be hosting a welcome ceremony.

The crowd is silent in reply.

Evgeni: I understand your concerns. I know you don't want Zeno to interfere with your lives, nor do you want their troops stationed here.

Evgeni: And I would remind you that they have honored their side of the deal for decades now.

A callused hand rises up to break the silence.

Knut: We give them runium ore, and they supply us in return. It should be as simple as that.

Knut: Always it has been this way, since my grandfather's time.

Evgeni: Times have changed, Comrade Knut.

Evgeni: In the old days, Zeno used to pay us generously for mining this runium, because our ore was necessary for their arcane combat vehicles.

Evgeni: But now, we have nearly exhausted all our mines. You know this better than I do.

Knut: ...

Knut: But isn't there some other work we can do? Already, we built our own houses, and now we even grow our own crops.

Resident I: He's right. Why must we work with Zeno if we could feed ourselves?

Resident II: Comrades, calm yourselves! Evgeni is doing this for everybody's sake—have you forgotten about those little monsters?

Resident II: Is there anyone left on our defense team that hasn't been injured fighting them?

The audience falls quiet. Evgeni seizes on their momentary pause.

Evgeni: It is as Comrade Nikita said.

Evgeni: The critters are running rampant these days. Not only have they occupied most of our mines, some have even found their way into the town.

Evgeni: Do you really think we can protect our people with our small defense team? Don't you care about your neighbors' safety? Do you want to keep Rayashki an isolated town just to let it die?

Vila: Rayashki is more than an isolated town, Evgeni.

Vila: And we all know that.

Evgeni: But this is the reality we all must face now.

The scales on Vila's face rise involuntarily. She holds her stare.

Workers, cooks, security personnel ... Soon, all of Rayashki has joined in.

Knut: Comrade Evgeni. It was your idea to turn to these Zeno big guys for help. But you never even asked what we think, did you?

Knut: So you can't blame us for disagreeing now.

Evgeni: I'm doing this for your good.

His assurances did not seem to have much impact on the crowd.

A cold wind passes across the square.

Vila: We can take care of ourself- ...

She has more to say, but as she moves to speak, her scales stand on edge and shiver audibly.

She holds her hand up, signaling to the crowd. There is a scent on the wind—danger is near.

???: *roars*

A horde of hairy critters burst into the square.

Vila: Everyone, watch out!

She picks up a wooden chair to fend them off.

Evgeni: Defense team!

Guard I: On it!

???: *wails*

The critters flee in a panic.

If nothing else, the attack served to bring the town together again.

Evgeni: I salute your sense of smell, Comrade Vila. We could have suffered much more severe consequences without your forewarning.

Handshakes and salutes are shared, their dispute now absent from anyone's mind.

Vila: Think nothing of it. It's just a reflex reaction when there is danger nearby.

She touches her scales, pressing them down until they settle.

Evgeni: But this incursion has proved my point. We need Zeno's help.

Evgeni: The other townspeople are not gifted with your set of talents. We are all vulnerable to the growing dangers, wouldn't you agree?

Evgeni: I only ask you to put yourself in their shoes.

He speaks softly, evenly, but even so, the words land like a heavy blow.

Vila: Your criticism is valid and well-accepted, Comrade Evgeni.

Vila: Perhaps I could agree with your plan. Provided Zeno's presence is a temporary one. We just don't want them to change things for us here.

The atmosphere in the square moves from joyful to serious, as the meaning of their words takes hold.

Evgeni: I'm glad that you have finally come to realize what is best for us.

Evgeni: Zeno is known for their rigorous methods and rational decision-making, and they are committed to maintaining peace around the world. I'm sure they will make the right decision.

Evgeni: They trusted us to supply their ore, and we have faithfully played our part in supporting them. Thanks to our help, Zeno has successfully tackled many international issues.

Evgeni: It has always been them and us together, fighting for a better world.

Knut: Hahaha! When he puts it that way, he's right. We should be proud of our cooperation!

Even without a punchline, Knut's deep belly laugh breaks the tension.

Evgeni: Therefore, we will show our appreciation to Zeno for the contributions they've made to the world with our help. Now, let's continue our rehearsals.

As the adults return to their duties, a sharp-eyed child notices that someone is missing.

Pasono: Have you seen Avgust? I can't find him!

Vila: Hmm?!

Nina: Strange, where did he go?

Pyotr: Hmph, looking for any Alenka left in the cupboards, I'd bet! He's always breaking the rules doing whatever he wants.

Nina: We shouldn't talk badly about our classmate, Pyotr! He's one of us.

Pyotr lowers his head, his face crumpling, until at last, he lets out a grumble fit for a bear.

Pyotr: *sighs* Yes, you're right. I just want everyone to do their best, even him.

Vila: Don't worry, kids. We will find him.

Vila pats Nina's shoulder softly.

Vila: A child is missing, Comrade Evgeni. I suggest a temporary suspension of our rehearsals.

Evgeni murmurs a half-response, until he catches the weight of her words.

Evgeni: Urgh, it must be that strange kid again! He is always sneaking away like this.

Avgust has been no small trouble in the past. Evgeni frowns, but Vila's determined glare tells him "No" is not an acceptable answer.

Vila: He is only trying to understand the world in his own way.

Evgeni: ...

8#1

Big Discoveries!

FR-02

Children's Square, Rayashki

The question of where their curious little dreamer has disappeared soon becomes a true conundrum,

as their search through the dockyard, the post office, and even the town phone booth reveals no trace of him.

This is, of course, because he has assigned himself a more critical mission: welcoming newcomers.

A difficult task, especially when it leads him so far away. But he is not alone. His sunflower hops along with him.

Abandoned Mine, Rayashki

Avgust: Vila once said that sunflowers mean warmth, and that makes them everyone's friends.

Avgust: They would warmly welcome every guest that comes to town.

Avgust: Just like my best friend here, right?

He raises the sunflower in his hand and whispers softly to its petals.

Avgust: Best friends ... Everyone should have a best friend.

He then picks up the pendant.

Following his whispers, the pendant emits a faint glow.

Avgust: ♪ ... ♫ ...

Avgust: Alright! Now here are big friends, small friends, many, many friends!

Avgust: So that our new guests won't feel so lonely when they come!

The small footprints continue forward through the snow, imprinting over older, larger steps.

He has nearly caught up with Rayashki's newest guest.

???: Amazing! I've never seen such a highly mutated Ijiraq before.

???: I would have missed these precious research opportunities if there weren't a gathering in the town.

Windsong: Windsong, seems like life has been good to you and your theory.

She stares intently at the beasts in front of her, her written notes hardly keeping pace with her whispered observations.

Windsong: The disorder in ley energy here has not only caused the exhaustion of the runium mines, but has also mutated local critters to varying degrees.

Windsong: ...

Windsong: Then Zeno was right. No wonder they have sent so many researchers here to look for abnormalities, even the crank ones like me.

Windsong: It's obvious that this town has more to it than a handful of overly active critters.

Windsong: But they don't seem especially interested in the mutant ones either.

Windsong: Zeno, what were you looking for here?

Avgust: *happy chuckles*

Windsong: ...!

A sudden movement passing under her coat brings her out of her monologue.

flop

Windsong: Mmm?!

Windsong: Hey! Let go! Let go of my leg!

Avgust: *sniffs*

Avgust: Strange! You're not a fox, and you're not a sable.

The appearance of this unknown child brings, at first, confusion, followed swiftly by panic.

Windsong: Hey! Kid, what are you doing?!

She picks herself up, dusting off a small flurry of snowflakes.

Unfortunately, Windsong is not the only one startled by the child.

Ijiraq: *roars*

Windsong: Oh, shoot. Ijiraqs are usually known for their good temper. It seems to not apply to their mutant kin.

Rugged antlers aim squarely at the researcher.

The creature's nose puffs with each aggravated breath.

Windsong: Fine.

Windsong: Природа это числа и черты.

Avgust: Umm?

Avgust: Are you building blocks here?!

Ijiraq: *roars*

The startled Ijiraq runs off into the distance.

Windsong: Phew! Lucky for us, it seems to still be afraid of the dark, like the rest of its kind.

Windsong: It's finally over.

Her satisfaction fades as she takes stock of her surroundings.

Windsong: Oh! My materials!

Avgust: Wow! You are the most "most"!

His little hands struggle to reach any higher. He pats the freezing hand of the researcher.

Avgust: You drove away all the bad critters and protected everyone!

Avgust: The swans on the stage, the big burning furnaces in the factory, and even the uncles sleeping in the mine with Papa ... I think they would all give you a big thumbs-up!

Windsong: ...?

She sighs, resigned that she must now deal with her uninvited guest.

Though, in fact, she is the one here uninvited.

Windsong: Ahem, you can call me Windsong.

Windsong: Just to be clear, I'm not a spy, kid. I'm just a traveler staying in town for the moment.

She casually raises an identification card in her hand, a card adorned with a familiar sunflower pattern.

Avgust: Oh! But I have never seen you before!

Avgust: Do you also like to rest in the water? Like Vila?

Avgust: Do you also have a beautiful blue tail?

His strange questions prove difficult to parse, even one at a time, but the little boy circles around her, unleashing more in salvo after salvo.

Windsong: I have no idea what you're talking about, but I'm certain that I'm not what you think I am, little fellow.

Windsong: I am a researcher. We often stay in quiet corners when we work on a project, so you won't see us often. Understand?

Avgust: Researchers? Like those people on TV?

Avgust: I saw them stand on a tall tall stage, with flowers in their arms. They spoke a lot and cried, and then they were given a shiny medal.

Avgust: Vila said the medals were to praise them for being very clever.

Avgust: Can I see your medal?

Windsong: ...

This last salvo penetrated deep. Windsong's face twitches unnaturally.

Windsong: Haha. Oh! The crystal on you looks stunning. It looks purer than those in the mine carts.

Her gaze centered on it, a beautiful crystal hanging on the boy's neck. A chance possibly to stop his barrage of questions.

Avgust: Of course. Papa gave it to me.

His small chest swells with pride.

Windsong: It is precious, but also very dangerous. A crystal like this is almost as volatile as undiluted runium ore. They use this stuff for war machines!

Windsong: Kid, listen to me, put that away. Go home now, and don't let anyone see it. Understand?

Windsong: It could stimulate the critters' appetite!

Avgust: Ah!

Windsong nods with satisfaction, eager to see him leave.

Unfortunately, the sunflower gently brushes up against her arm once more.

Avgust: Can you build a very, very tall wall? One that can protect the whole town? Like what you did with the blocks?

Windsong: I'm sorry, little fellow.

She points to the now-empty patch of snow-covered ground.

Windsong: That was just a trick. It won't last long.

Avgust: No, that was amazing!

Avgust: Nina, Knut, Vila—everyone should learn from you!

Avgust: Could I make the dirt and stones listen to me like you did one day? Will I be great like you?

Windsong: ...

Windsong: A strange kid like you should live in the Age of Aquarius and be a part of the New Age Movement, or become some kind of Yogi doing meditation.

Windsong: And do it anywhere but here.

Avgust: The New Age Movement? What is that?!

Her helpless attempt at turning him away goes without notice; worse still, it seems to intrigue him.

Avgust: Is that where you're from?

Windsong: It's not a place. It's a spirit of a time. Full of interesting things—like crystals, new schools of thought, many crazy and creative ideas.

Avgust: Will the sun close its eyes? Will the dark clouds spit on people?

Avgust: Will their ships blow bubbles under the water?

Somehow, the persistent questions stop being a source of annoyance.

The subtle warmth of his boundless wonder shakes loose the frost from her heart.

Her smile turning from feigned to genuine.

Windsong: Of course! They even believe that the world is a giant piece of blank paper, and they are the artists drawing on it.

Windsong: And not only that, they are obsessed with bizarre ideas. Where did the Stonehenge on the Salisbury Plain come from? Where are the ships and planes which traveled past the Sargasso Sea now?

Avgust: I like them!

The child's voice blurs the edges between reality and pleasant memories of her past, to a time when there were others that thought like her.

Windsong: They called themselves ley hunters, the apprentices of a once-renowned school of thought. However, few people in academic circles accepted the idea of ley lines as an answer to their questions.

Windsong: So for these ley hunters, it has been a long walk through a dark night.

Avgust: Then they can come to Rayashki! Here, the sun never sets! Half the year, anyways.

Avgust: Then I can be their friend! And when I grow up, I will be a ley hunter too!

Windsong tightens her scarf, as if warding off a chill.

Windsong: I'm afraid it's a bit too late, little fellow.

Windsong: Most have already given up. They lost interest in solving the mysteries and lost their faith in finding the curves and the lines. So the study of ley lines has been all but abandoned.

Windsong: There's only one fool left that hasn't given it up.

She speaks wistfully, entranced in that daze of memory, oblivious to the nearing sound of footsteps behind her.

Avgust: Shhh!

Windsong: ...?

Vila: And you, I suppose, are this "only one fool," yes?

Vila pulls Avgust toward her protectively and reproaches him with a ruffle of the child's hair.

Windsong: Ah! Please, ma'am, believe me, I am not a child abductor!

Vila: Well ...

Windsong offers a pained gesture towards the boy.

Vila: I think this isn't a good place to receive our guest. We have much more appropriate arrangements for new friends.

Vila: But ...

Vila: If our guest has any ill intentions, we will retaliate.

Windsong: Umm.

8#1

Needle-Grass

FR-03

People's Square, Rayashki

The group, each harboring their own thoughts, returns toward the small town. Vila and Avgust humming out a sing-song tune.

And anxious Windsong remains silent for the journey.

Vila wheels around just as they arrive at the outskirts, keeping up the cadence of the song.

Vila: We're here.

Vila: Thank you for taking care of our little Comrade Avgust, miss.

Windsong: ...?

Windsong: You mean I'm not here to be questioned? Or arrested?

Vila: *chuckles* Of course not.

Vila: Perhaps we are a little too optimistic, but when we meet a stranger, we prefer to welcome them.

Vila looks over the awkward figure, reading the expression on her face. The researcher breaks the silence with a stumble.

Windsong: Oh, well, I'm Windsong.

Vila: That's a very unique name. And where is it you come from?

Windsong: From the east side of the Dniester River.

Vila's scales are hit with a sea breeze. It halts her and their conversation.

Vila: *sniffs*

Windsong: ...?!

The teacher breaks out from her pause.

Vila: No offense, Ms. But you have a complicated and unfamiliar scent about you.

Vila: The smell of hard rocks, a lighthouse by the sea, rainwater in a humid summer. Mm. Nothing hostile, though.

Windsong: *chuckles* I think most rootless travelers like me smell like that.

Vila: Welcome to Rayashki, Ms. Windsong.

Vila motions inward to the town.

Windsong: Thank you.

Windsong: I understand your caution. But ...

Windsong is seized by her own suspicion, spying the unusual scales on her host's neck.

Vila catches the glance. She subtly tugs at her sleeve and shrinks her neck into her coat, taking a few cautious steps backward.

Vila: You have nothing to worry about; it's not a disease.

Vila: Anyway, let's talk about you. I heard that you're a researcher.

Vila: Not long ago, many of your peers visited here. They wandered around and looked under every rock and floorboard in the town, like you do. I thought perhaps they were attracted here by the town itself.

Vila: But regrettably, not long after, they left one after another in disappointment.

Vila: I was disappointed, too.

There is a curiousness in her tone.

Vila: Will you be like them?

Windsong: Haha.

Windsong: Those people are famous scholars; of course, they won't spend too much time on a project with unclear prospects. But I, I'm used to those.

She spreads her hands out to the town, with nothing more to say.

Vila: I salute you for your courage and spirit of exploration.

Windsong: I thought you ... I thought you might be more hostile to me. Shouting things like "Who do you think you are to prowl about on our private property!"

Vila: ...?

Windsong: Many see the study of ley lines like finding a needle in the grass of a Siberian field—wasted effort with negligible results.

Vila: There's no such thing as meaningless work.

Vila: It doesn't matter who you are, where you're from, or what you do. You will find your purpose here.

Vila shifts her gaze over to Avgust, who has been found and surrounded by the other children not far away.

Windsong: Is that so? No wonder how you have such an unusual student like Avgust.

Vila: All that childhood wonder, innocence—somehow you've preserved it in him, haven't you?

The children seem unconcerned with the new adult; they have their own world and their own rules to be addressed.

Avgust: Is the show finished?

Nina: We cancelled our rehearsal, Avgust. Mr. Evgeni just left red-faced.

Pyotr: Yes! And he canceled the "Friendship" cheese on the food menu, all thanks to you.

Avgust: But I was welcoming our new friend!

Pyotr: And we have lost our cheese because of you. This is all your fault!

Pyotr: You're the most bothersome kid in Rayashki!

Avgust: I know that word! "Most" means the best! So thank you, Pyotr.

Pyotr: You!

The other children gather close.

Pasono: Avgust, we don't see anyone new here. You're not lying again, are you?

Avgust: She's with Vila! They greet each other, share footprints, and even sing together.

Avgust: Windsong is also the "best"! She can draw many lines on the snow, and even on a seagull.

Pyotr: ...

Pyotr: We're not having another freak in town, right?

Nina: Do you mean drawing on the blackboard? Like Ms. Vila did?

Avgust playfully shakes his head, feigning an air of mystery.

Avgust: She made the earth turn into a tall tall wall, and she blew her breath at it, and made a building appear.

Avgust: If we had enough ley hunters like her working together, we would be able to send sunflowers high into the sky!

Pyotr: Ah, that's not so tough! All the men in town know how to build stuff like that!

Pyotr: When we grow up, we will work like them, with hoes and shovels.

Pasono: But that will take ages.

Nina: If we can learn how to build like the ley hunters, then we could help the adults right now!

Pyotr: Don't listen to Avgust!

The children discuss the notion animatedly. Pyotr finds himself squeezed out of their huddle.

He puffs his cheeks and hurries over to the adults.

Pyotr: Greetings, Ms. Windsong.

Windsong: Mm?

Pyotr: Is it true? Can you really shape the earth into different things and build things from it?

Windsong: Not exactly. The things I build with my arcane skill have only a momentary effect. I can't use it that way. I learned it as a part of my research while studying ley lines.

The other children join in.

Nina: Ms. Windsong, those things Avgust told us, are they true?

Nina: The sun that closes its eyes, the dark clouds that spit on people, and the lines that can reveal everything.

Pasono: Ms. Windsong, will you be our teacher, like Ms. Vila?

Pyotr: Can you prove anything?

Vila: Kids. One question at a time.

The children surround Windsong, catching her off guard.

She looks apologetically at Vila.

Windsong: Sorry, Ms. Vila. I should explain it to them.

Windsong: Mine is not a ... formal discipline. Many people believe that it "relies too much on the observations of arcanists" and "the conclusions aren't useful for the public."

Windsong: So it is best that you kids do not study it.

She shrugs her shoulders.

Windsong: A pursuit of passion, fit for only a very stubborn fool like me.

Vila: I see.

Vila nods in understanding.

Vila: Then, you must show us all about it. Shouldn't she, kids?

Vila: I'm sure Ms. Windsong would be very happy to give us a special lesson about her studies.

Windsong: Huh?!

Avgust: Yay!

Escaping this unasked-for obligation may prove more difficult than expected.

Windsong: Ms. Vila! I thought I made myself clear!

Vila: You have worked hard in this "pursuit of passion," haven't you?

Windsong: Regardless, the study of ley lines is ... Well, it's useless.

Windsong lightly taps her yellowed notebook filled with cryptic scribbles and notes.

Vila: Useless?

Windsong: These kids should learn something like geography. It's a much more thorough and important field.

Windsong: As far as the general public and academic institutions are concerned, the study of ley lines is just a niche aspect of geography, worse still, one that is solely accessible to arcanists.

Windsong: To devote any real time to its investigation would take up valuable research funds and equally valuable researchers.

Vila: At least that was how they felt about it.

Vila furrows her brow.

Windsong: Who can say for certain?

Vila: What about you? Do you also think that the study of ley lines is a waste of funds and manpower?

Windsong: I, of course, I don't. Through ley lines, we can detect arcanum-related events in the area, learn about local arcane creatures, and find the secrets hidden both above and below the earth's surface.

Windsong: But, I can't yet prove this to people.

Vila places her hand on Windsong's shoulder.

Vila: Well, you don't have to prove it alone.

Vila: It doesn't matter what others think of your work. The only important thing is finding its uses.

Windsong: ...

Vila: At first, Rayashki was just a remote village far north in the Arctic Circle. People came here to share a dream of a better future. It was only by luck that we found the runium.

Vila: Then Zeno approached us and became our business partner.

Vila: For over 60 years, people here have worked together to make it what it is now.

Vila: We built the school, the swimming pool, and the cinema ... For everyone.

Vila: Rayashki embraces and takes in every newcomer. You and your studies are no exception.

Vila: This is where our paths meet.

Vila smiles warmly. It hits like a warm sea breeze.

Windsong: ...

A pair of hands, concealing sharp scales, extends toward Windsong.

Vila: Please know that ...

Vila: I'm not just doing this for you. I'm doing this for a better future.

Vila glances at the children not far away. Some of them seem to be solemnly saluting a sunflower, as if it were a security team guard.

Vila: A well-rounded education is vital in bringing up the next generation of scientists and workers.

Vila: Our children should learn more about this world, even from those perspectives and types of knowledge that aren't widely accepted.

Windsong looks out to them and meets the face of her unexpected friend. He waves back excitedly.

Windsong: Thank you, Ms. Vila.

She clasps her hand; it is colder than expected, but welcoming.

8#1

Said the Gardener to Flowers

FR-04

Windsong: The study of ley line sees the world as a clear map.

Windsong: The cities look like squares to us, while natural landscapes appear to be curves overlapping one another.

Windsong: Many bizarre places in the world, such as the location of the Tunguska explosion or the mysterious 30th Parallel North, can't be drawn in squares and curves like cities and ordinary landscapes.

Windsong: We need to find a way to indicate them,

Windsong: in a clear, precise way.

Avgust: It's a maze!

Windsong: Well, it is the ley line map of a city. But you are right. It does look like a maze.

Windsong: To begin with, I should introduce the most crucial concept in the study of ley lines—that of ley energy.

Windsong: It is a special energy which we can easily detect throughout the town. See how it comes out from underneath the ground and goes into the local biosphere, circulating around like a system.

Windsong: If we think of the town's ley lines as a food web, then ley energy lies at its foundation.

Avgust: Like how big fish eat small fish, and small fish eat even smaller fish!

The boy's comparative is simple but essentially correct.

Windsong: Exactly. They are the smallest "fish" eaten by the "big fish." If we catch the "big fish" and study what they eat, we will know where to find the other "big fish."

Windsong: And the ley energy, I mean, when the "big fish" die and break down, the "small fish" will go back to where they first came from. The circulation goes on and on.

Vila: You've put it very well, Ms. Windsong.

Vila: Like the rainwater that comes from the ocean, to the rivers, and returns back to the ocean.

Her tone rises, the scales along her neck unfurling slightly.

Windsong: You are a quick learner.

Windsong: But it is not exactly like water. The concentration of ley energy is far more noticeable than that of a lake or a school of fish. Once we find its densest spot, we will be able to trace it back to its source.

Nina: Then what are these bright spots?

Windsong: These are the energy-rich locations. In a way, they indicate the energy flow.

Avgust: So many, they look like stars in the sky!

Windsong: Yes, and finding these locations can be very costly in terms of time and manpower.

Pasono: Then, what do we do after finding them?

Windsong: They can "tell" us many things. The ley hunters will follow their courses, analyze the components in them, and match those components to each resource.

Windsong: Some of the components don't match with any of the known resources, which means there might be a new resource waiting to be discovered.

Windsong: Of course, from the ley energy, we can also learn about the local critters.

Pyotr: You talk about strange things, almost like Avgust does!

He pouts, finding all of this hard to believe.

Pyotr: These are just lines.

Avgust: Like dancing earthworms! They wriggle, they twist, they are having fun!

Avgust: Jumping on the waves, then into the little boxes, and back into the little balls!

Pyotr: *sighs* Great, we have two of them now.

Classroom, Rayashki

Nina: They look interesting, but we don't really understand.

Her theories are a bit too complex for children at this level, even with the aid of a drawing.

Windsong: Cheer up, kids. It's not finished yet.

Windsong: Ley line cartography is complicated. It takes the efforts of many ley hunters working together, investigating the area, even braving dangerous and forbidden places.

Windsong: To this day, we've never been able to finish a completed ley energy map.

Their enthusiasm dims, but some remain immersed in the world of ley lines.

Avgust raises up the incomplete drawing.

Avgust: I know! I know it now!

Avgust: This is Rayashki!

Vila: ...?

Pasono: Ah! I see it too! And here is the swimming pool. That little square is our square. These little balls are our homes!

Nina: Oh! I live here, the third ball on the left of yours.

The children react with surprise. Windsong applauds.

Windsong: You're very bright, Avgust. This is the ley energy map of Rayashki.

Nina: But, Ms. Windsong, why are you mapping the energy of our town?

Nina: Have you found any secrets that we don't know?

Windsong: Children, right now, you can only see what's above the ground, but there is even more ley energy beneath the ground.

Windsong lowers her head, feeling momentarily transported back to a time long past, while her audience listens intently below.

Windsong: Will the sun always be in the sky? Will the glaciers ever melt away? What lies in the darkness beneath us?

Windsong: Are there other critters around here that you've never seen? How should we deal with them?

This topic sets off a clamor of excitement from the children.

Pasono: I heard once that there were many strange footprints next to the school windows.

Nina: Uncle Patrik saw it! A monster with six legs, and each one has spikes!

Windsong: That must be a Qiqirn, a small sized canidae critter, mostly seen in cold areas.

Windsong: But the ley energy might have affected the weather of their habitat, or they wouldn't be here in Rayashki in summer. The deep blue line here shows that particular one's movement.

Pyotr: Or maybe Uncle Patrik could have drunk too much.

Windsong: The ley energy accumulated in them suggests that they mostly feed on moss and worms under the snow and stay near town.

Windsong: We can infer that this is a docile, herbivorous kind of critter that is merely curious about human behavior. I think feeding them will be much more useful than driving them away.

Vila nods thoughtfully.

Vila: Since these critters began to overrun the area, the defense team has encountered many new creatures. I can feel there's something strange about them, but I can't yet understand the differences.

Vila: You provided a different angle on the situation, Ms. Windsong. I believe it could help the defense team greatly.

These new discoveries have provoked interest in the teacher and her students alike.

Avgust: The fires in the furnaces are out, the bees and kites dance around the pond, white mosses on the wall.

Avgust: Oh, oh! Stones will fall down from the sky!

Windsong: Huh?!

His bizarre yet ominous statements seem to upset the others.

Pyotr: Stop saying these strange things, Avgust!

Pyotr: The defense team will keep the critters out of town and protect everyone!

Pyotr: And there will not be any stones falling from the sky!

Pyotr stands up, his fists clenched and face flush red.

Avgust: Is everything alright, Pyotr?

Pyotr: You! You're lying! Rayashki is safe. It will be our home forever!

Windsong: I hate to tell you this, kid. But what Avgust just said could be right. I have the same feeling that ...

Windsong: The good weather here won't last too long.

She gazes outward. The sky above is gray and growing darker.

Windsong: Look at those thick, gray lines.

Windsong: Those are the traces of cloud movements and moisture. Now, they're mingled together.

Nina: But the sun will still be shining. Ms. Vila said that the polar day will last for a very, very long time!

Windsong: Ms. Vila was right, and past statistics don't lie. According to the data, the weather here should continue for the next few months.

Windsong: Yet the ley lines say otherwise. They say the weather will be extremely unpredictable.

Pyotr: You are making things up! The forecaster on TV said the weather in Rayashki will be temperate in the coming months.

Windsong: And the weather forecaster was right according to his analysis, but life is full of surprises.

Vila: I know why you're concerned, Ms. Windsong. I feel the glaciers are melting slightly faster than usual. There's going to be a warm front forming from the melting water.

Windsong looks at her audience. She had half-hoped for some opposition from them.

Nina: But, but will there really be stones falling from the sky?

Windsong: I can't say anything for certain just yet, kid.

Windsong: All I have is this incomplete map, and as you can see, many sources of the marks and traces haven't been located, which means we can't come up with a precise calculation.

Windsong: But there's no question that Rayashki will soon face many challenges. The weather could become much worse, the environment might change, maybe some unknown critters might turn up.

Pyotr: ...

Pyotr: Liar! You are all liars!

Pyotr: Rayashki is our home, so it can't be dangerous!

The class bell rings at an inopportune moment.

The children rush out of the classroom one after another.

Avgust: Pyotr, you can't fly if your feathers get wet!

Windsong sighs. Although she hasn't fully adapted to her new role, she must keep up with the children.

Vila intercepts her.

Vila: They will need some time to take in all this new knowledge, don't you agree?

Windsong: I thought I could handle all their questions. I think I made things worse. Sorry.

Vila: Have faith in them. They will come around.

Children's Square, Rayashki

Pyotr squats on the ground, muttering softly to himself while rolling some pebbles.

A sunflower, and the boy attached to it, approaches.

Pyotr: Are you here to laugh at me?

Pyotr: All these stories of monsters and falling stones—they aren't good at all!

Pyotr: I overheard Mr. Evgeni talking.

Pyotr: He said the town has so many problems, and soon, what some people think will decide our future.

Pyotr: If people believe in those terrible stories, maybe they will be scared, and they won't come back to Rayashki.

Pyotr: Our town will be forgotten.

Avgust: But, I wasn't lying.

Choking tears fill their small world.

Rustling sounds come up from behind the flowerbed.

???: *roars*

Crimson eyes set in a furry head observe them with curiosity.

Avgust: Mm? Hello, Qiqirn!

Pyotr: What, what are you doing?! I will draw its attention. You go find the defense team for help!

The older boy opens his trembling arms defensively.

Children's Square, Rayashki

A mound of sunflower seeds is presented on a pair of tender hands.

Moist nostrils approach, and then a rough tongue greedily curls around the seeds.

Avgust: *chuckles* Heh-heh, it's itchy!

The Qiqirn purrs contentedly as the now empty hands stroke it gently but confidently.

Avgust: It feels warm, doesn't it?

Avgust: Ms. Windsong said they can be our friends, that they would bring seeds to every corner of the town.

Pyotr: Like a gardener?

Another pair of hands reach out to cautiously caress its fur.

Avgust: Yes!

Avgust: Go plant more sunflowers, Qiqirn!

The deep blue creature darts away.

Pyotr: ...

Pyotr: So, Ms. Windsong was not a liar.

8#1

Accordion

FR-05

Port, Rayashki

The warm current of the ocean is a stranger to this place.

The long-silent dock seems to be pining for use, for visitors, to bustle once more with industry.

A lone figure stands there, resolute, unblinking.

Evgeni: ...

Vila stretches out as she stands beside him. The scales on her wrists and ankles catch the light, shimmering against a white reflection in the water.

Vila: Do you really think it's a good idea to turn to Zeno for help?

Evgeni: We have drawn almost every man and woman from the mining facilities to get rid of the critters nesting around the port.

Evgeni: Most of the defense team were injured. Some lightly, but others got much worse. It will be weeks before they can return to duty.

Evgeni: If an attack like the one at the rehearsal happens again, I'm not sure we will be able to protect ourselves.

His stance doesn't waver, but his face turns stiffly toward the abandoned mine far in the distance.

Kittiwakes screech as they swoop down over the vast white tundra.

Vila: ...

Evgeni: I know most of our people are frustrated with Zeno's arrival. But I expected better from you, Vila.

Evgeni: People trust you, and they will follow you, but that doesn't make you right. Maybe you're still too young to see the dangers.

Vila: I might be wrong, but history is a long lesson in learning what is right through being unafraid to be wrong.

Evgeni: Sadly, we don't have time for trial and error.

Vila: And this is your excuse for making decisions for us against our will?

Evgeni: I will hold myself responsible for my decisions. In that, you have my word.

Their conversation reaches deadlock once again.

Fortunately, elsewhere, there are others with fewer and simpler burdens.

Avgust: Today is the day of our welcome ceremony. Vila said, when the bell rings, the important people from the tortoise academy will arrive.

Avgust: Everyone looks excited.

Avgust: Nina has put on her best dress. I know she will be great on stage.

Avgust: Pasono will duel with Pyotr. It's his duty to protect the princess.

Avgust: As for me, I got a new job from Mr. Evgeni.

Avgust: "Salute, shake hands, and give them the warmest welcome."

The child nods solemnly, aware of the weighty mission he must undertake.

The little standard-bearer stands ready to receive Rayashki's latest guests.

Qiqirn: Boawh ... arrh!

Avgust: What this? There are bubbles in the water!

The critter pops its head out of the water, two eyes staring out at the boy with bewilderment.

Avgust: We meet again, Qiqirn! Are you planting sunflowers under the water?

Qiqirn: *blows bubbles*

Avgust: Have you brought your friends?

Bubbles swell on the open surface of the water as more Qiqirns break up through the slurry of ice.

Though their peculiar appearances differ from one to the next, they all possess large, lamp-like eyes that look out and around with curiosity.

Avgust: One, two ... Oh, your friends also have six legs!

Avgust: Look, they are wearing needlegrass and flat files on their legs.

Avgust: Are you also here for the ceremony?

The child takes pride in his imagined duties.

Avgust: Welcome, Qiqirn and friends!

Avgust: Welcome to the prettiest town in all of the Arctic—Rayashki!

Avgust: Please enjoy our song—

His cheeks flush as spirited childish voices reverberate in unison out into the sea ahead.

Seagulls take flight as a distant stern statue springs to life and rushes over.

Evgeni: Comrade Avgust, what are you doing?!

Avgust: Oh? I'm welcoming the Qiqirn.

The child happily salutes the Qiqirns as they step onto the dock.

Evgeni: Get out of there. They are dangerous!

Evgeni: Defense team, drive them away!

Vila: Wait! These are Qiqirn. They are not aggressive! They are just curious about us. The kids seem to like them.

The defense team moves swiftly and without hesitation.

Evgeni: Get rid of them.

Guard I: As you command, comrade!

Sprays of bullets and bursts of flame disrupt the water's surface, following the Qiqirns as they dive in, one after another.

Alarms wail in the distance, but the Qiqirns are already long gone.

The children who came to see them are left on the ground, gripping their hats over their ears.

Nina: The Qiqirns are all gone. I think they don't like us anymore.

Kids: ...

Vila: Comrade Evgeni ...

Evgeni: Take the kids back to where they were, Comrade Vila. It was your duty to protect them.

His orders fizzle out as soon as they are said.

Pyotr: Maybe if we make the town a better place, more friends will come back.

Pyotr: Then they will also come back!

Pasono: That makes sense!

The researcher observes all this from a nearby vantage. Her notebook rustles with a sigh.

Windsong: The family of Qiqirn includes dozens of subspecies, but none of them are so greatly adapted to water as this. That is to say ...

Windsong: They might also be affected by the ley energy under Rayashki.

Windsong: Pity that they were driven away. There was much we could have learned from them.

She looks up. A blanket of clouds obscures the sun, with only a few rays of light breaking through.

Windsong: *gasps*

Windsong: The temperature here is rising much faster than expected, and much earlier in the season.

Windsong: I imagine if you asked the weather bureau, they would say this is just an "odd occurrence of unseasonable weather outside of expected ranges."

boom

The booming sound of cannon fire interrupts Windsong's train of thought.

Evgeni: It's time. The Zeno investigators should be here any minute.

Evgeni: I must stress again how important this ceremony could be for our future.

Evgeni: Our town's economy is facing a cliff, and I am sure each one of you has noticed the increased rationing.

Evgeni: If we wish to take care of our people in the future and protect our friends and family from these frequent critter attacks, we need Zeno's support.

Evgeni: So we will work with Zeno. Because we must!

Evgeni: The future of Rayashki is in our hands, so is the future of every comrade here.

Evgeni: And we need the cooperation of every man and woman here.

His stare falls toward the Rusalka's vibrant tail.

After a pause, his target replies.

Vila: Zeno's ships are very fast, so, as soon as they appear on the horizon,

Vila: our ceremony will begin.

Choir Members: Understood.

The choir rises in unison, looking out at the pale blue horizon.

The sea responds placidly.

Salmon leap out from the water. Seagulls circling along the empty coastline.

Yet no sign of the anticipated ship appears.

The quiet expectations of the adults set the children to whisper.

Pasono: Zeno is late.

Pyotr: So late that Ms. Vila would say they were absent!

Nina: Do you think something bad happened to them?

Avgust: What are they doing there?

No answers come, but a new event catches their attention.

Avgust: Oh! Something is falling!

Avgust: Light and soft, like a polar bear's hair!

Dark clouds press down on them, blocking out the final rays of sunlight.

Avgust: Poor bear, losing all his hair.

Snowflakes flutter down across the gray sky.

Converging in the blustering wind, they fall towards the town.

Nina: Mmm?

Pasono: It's snow!

Pyotr: What?! How can there be snow in summer?

Pasono: Mm? Is this related to the strange thing Avgust said earlier?

Nina: If so, I'm happy that these aren't stones or a dark cloud's spit.

The children huddle near Avgust, astonished by the accuracy of his predictions.

Pasono: Avgust, I can't believe it! You were never right before!

Nina: *shivers* Oh, oh, it's chilly. The snow is biting against my skin.

Pyotr: I'm sorry, Avgust. I shouldn't call you a liar.

He lowers his head hesitantly.

Pyotr: But will Rayashki really get into trouble?

A gentle hand nudges Pyotr, a motion learned from someone older and wiser.

Avgust: Pyotr, we will not be defeated, not by clouds, or bears.

Avgust: Look!

Avgust: Mr. Tortoise is walking very slowly.

Avgust: But no one has left their position.

Avgust: For Rayashki.

Avgust: You little swans must go back to your lake too! Go as fast as you can!

Nina: We will!

Pyotr: Don't forget your own job, Avgust!

The children return to their positions and ready themselves.

Windsong: So, this milky white line is this snowstorm.

Windsong: The average temperature in Rayashki has reached its highest point in the last five years, which, together with the abnormally rich air moisture, has produced an unseasonal and odd kind of snow.

Windsong: The weather forecast was wrong; ley lines were right!

Windsong can't hide her excitement.

She leans up on a wall some distance from the event, her pen flying across page after page of notes.

Until she is compelled to snap back to reality.

Windsong: Mm?

The assembly before her has barely moved.

The snow claims more territory by the minute.

Over sea and land, piling up on the railings, and rising over boots, large and small.

Windsong: ...!

A distant foghorn accompanies the sight of a flag piercing up into the horizon. Zeno arrives at last.

Evgeni: Everyone, listen!

Evgeni: Our ceremony will begin.

Residents: As you command, comrade!

Evgeni: Music, please!

Residents: "Let go of yesterday, let it fade away."

Residents: "Each step paints a brand-new day."

Residents: "Don't look behind, no shadows will be seen in the daylight."

Residents: "Under brighter skies, we leave on our journey."

The steamship pulls into their rudimentary harbor, but no further movement follows.

A porthole opens, but no voice comes out, no sound whatsoever beyond the lapping waves.

A letter flutters out toward the anxious crowd.

???: It's a pleasure to speak to you all, our valued friends in Rayashki.

???: On behalf of Zeno Arms Academy, I am here to announce the details of the "Zeno-Rayashki Cooperation Agreement."

???: As many of you have expected, a squad of armed troops will soon be sent to aid you with the critter problem.

???: However, having given it careful consideration, we have decided that the town of Rayashki is no longer viable for our continued support and must be abandoned. We advise that all residents prepare to be transferred to a new post, immediately.

???: Thank you for your cooperation.

Vila: What?!

8#1

Good Days, Bad Days

FR-06

Meeting Room, Rayashki

Bertolt: I don't see the point of your reluctance.

The frowning master of ceremonies straightens the tortoise-patterned letter and then shoves it back into its envelope.

Bertolt: The letter conveyed Zeno's decision clearly.

Bertolt: I suggest we warm ourselves up with a few drinks before we go. Do you have any Stolich in town?

Bertolt: Better than sitting here dwelling on the things that cannot be changed.

Bertolt: Please tell me you have something like cocoa here.

Their long-awaited guest stretches lazily, as if no one is around, and sinks into the couch.

The tension in the air hangs like fumes waiting to ignite.

Vila: This is not what we agreed on earlier, Mr. Bertolt.

Evgeni: Calm yourself, Vila.

Bertolt: You must be mistaken, my very passionate friend.

Bertolt: Zeno sent a warning months ago. "The estimated value Rayashki can add to Zeno's program is less than satisfactory. Further support is no longer recommended."

Bertolt: "Should any new valuable resources be found in the region, please reply to this letter as soon as possible for further assessment."

Vila: ...!

Bertolt: Then we heard back from Rayashki.

Bertolt: In fact, the sender was you, Evgeni.

Evgeni: Yes, it was.

Bertolt: And it was you yourself that argued the most compelling point, I have to say. One that has drawn the higher-ups' attention, and the reason why I was sent here.

Bertolt: I believe you wrote: "I have total faith in the quality of the people of Rayashki. Their solidarity, dedication, and motivation have proven invaluable to us."

Bertolt: "I am certain they would carry those same strengths of character and skill to any post, no matter where they were assigned."

He folds the letter and hands it to Vila, her face blank as a canvas.

Evgeni: Zeno accepted my application.

Evgeni: Of course, I asked around before making my submission, and Zeno seemed to have a good reputation.

Evgeni: It was a golden opportunity to join them.

Bertolt: It is, but do not get us wrong. Our entrance requirements can be most difficult to meet.

Bertolt: Zeno only takes in the best of the best.

Vila: You want some of us to work for Zeno?!

Vila: You never told us anything like that, Evgeni!

Evgeni: Be reasonable, Vila. Some of us deserve this opportunity.

Vila: What about the others?! We have elders and children. Some of our comrades have been injured and even died in the mine; are we to forget their sacrifices?

She tries to suppress the gills on her neck as they heave violently.

Bertolt: Relax, my friend. That's why we sent our very best biological control squad.

Bertolt: We will escort you to the nearest shelter.

Another wave upon relentless waves of shock.

Evgeni: Face reality, Vila. I know how much effort we have put into building this town, and I understand you have this dream to fulfill.

Evgeni: But we must prepare for the worst: we may have to give up on our Rayashki.

He takes out a document covered in scratched notes and annotations and hands it to her.

Evgeni: Read this.

Vila: "Field investigation has confirmed that the remaining runium reserves in Rayashki are around 0.0173 kilotons, which is less than 0.275% of our average annual output."

Vila: "The mine is located high within the Arctic Circle, which has entailed significant transportation costs. The harsh environment is also wholly unsuitable for building any permanent processing facilities."

Vila: "In addition, military spending on the region has recently been elevated 3.61 times due to increasing animal and critter attacks, and that number is still rising."

Vila: "Clearly, the region is now incapable of self-management."

Vila: "According to the Guide on Global Humanitarian Aid by the Office for Disaster Risk Reduction of Zeno Arms Academy, we propose to ..."

Vila: "... send a special squad to the region to evacuate all local citizens and subsequently take care of the remaining biological control issues."

Bertolt: And our admission standards will be lowered—at Zeno's discretion—so that you will all find work with us somewhere.

Zeno's representative offers a timely, if unconvincing, supplement to the letter.

The paper creases and crumples into a ball in her hands.

Evgeni: I'm sorry, but this is reality.

Evgeni: From the start, this ore was the only thing they wanted from us.

Evgeni: The environment here has always been harsh for mining, but we overcame it and sent our shipments to wherever Zeno had need of them.

Bertolt: And I salute each one of you for your work, my friends.

Evgeni: But now, our mission is over.

There is no doubt in anyone's mind: runium has been the town's lifeblood and the key to its survival.

Evgeni: I believe all of you will continue to work hard in your new positions. No matter what ...

Vila: You shouldn't rush to a decision. We're discussing Rayashki's future here, Evgeni.

Vila: For six decades, the people here have put in great efforts to turn the town into what it is today. We won't leave just because you tell us so.

Vila: Our grandparents didn't even have construction equipment at the beginning. They built these houses with their own hands.

Vila: We shipped over the planting soil. We built walls to keep out the wind and snow.

Within the meeting room's cloistered walls, the air is heavy with moisture once more.

Evgeni: When you came here, you brought books for the children and introduced us to a species different than humans. You became one of us.

Evgeni: I am not happy about this either, Comrade Vila.

Vila: I won't buy that, Comrade Evgeni. This is not just about my dream, but everyone's dream.

Vila: Or have you forgotten what Rayashki was meant to be?

Evgeni: A utopia built for and by everyone. The voice of a better future, one which would sound across the land and seas.

Evgeni: I remember every word of it.

Evgeni's voice is low but still decisive.

Bertolt: You have my sympathy, friends.

Bertolt: Zeno has also suffered huge losses in many regions.

Bertolt: We have lost manpower, territory, armament factories, and even some of our affiliated military schools. Rayashki is but one of these losses.

Bertolt: We know how you feel right now.

He shrugs his shoulders, his face a picture of unhelpfulness.

Bertolt: But Zeno has its own problems to be faced.

Bertolt: And investing in these new industries, purchasing fancy equipment, all these things Rayashki will need ... All of this takes money. And even Zeno must be economical.

Vila: Shouldn't the people in Rayashki also benefit from these global benefits Zeno has promised?

Bertolt: We will get there, my friend. Maybe slowly, but we will get there. Trust me, Zeno has done everything they can for you.

Bertolt: We need to keep our eyes on our goals and stay on the right course, so that we won't get lost in these turbulent times, yes?

Vila: ...

He leans toward Vila, providing an unnecessary whisper.

Bertolt: I know how much faith these people have in you, and I believe you can show them a different perspective about these coming changes.

Bertolt: Of course, this will also help you during Zeno's assessment.

Vila: ...

Bertolt: Good luck, my friend.

8#1

A Paper Medal

FR-07

Hotel, Rayashki

Windsong: The reserves of runium running dry, the appearance of new critters, the sudden snowstorm.

Windsong: I've connected the ley lines of each of these phenomena. The map is nearly complete!

She unfolds the complex blueprint filled with various lines and marks.

Windsong: But still haven't traced many lines and marks back to their source.

Windsong: Perhaps if I go back to the factories, into the restricted zones ... But, I can't do that alone.

Windsong: Definitely not when the situation in town is so unstable.

Windsong collapses onto the table. An avalanche follows, covering her in layers of books and manuscripts.

The piles around her loom like a mountain range, casting her in shadow.

Windsong: Well, I should have given this up long ago. There's no chance that the study of ley lines will ever be accepted again.

Phantom voices of past mockery and scorn rise up to her ears.

"Reviewer": Regretfully, Ms. Windsong, with nothing but these outdated files and materials to back you up, there's simply no way to justify reinstating the study of ley lines into our curriculum.

"Reviewer": We don't have unlimited funds, and we must save our money for projects with greater potential. The study of ley lines is ...

"Reviewer": Of course, we might be able to consider new ideas and projects. You can't be allowed to do this on your own.

"Reviewer": You will need endorsements from the Institution of Geographic Studies, the Arcane Creature Society, or other such organizations.

"Reviewer": Let me think. Zeno seems to be interested in geographers recently. They've just recruited a number of researchers for a new commission. Maybe you should go try your luck with them.

An echo of a nursery rhyme rings out from beyond her self-made mountain range.

But she is all but oblivious to it.

Windsong: The submission date is getting closer each day, but I've made poor progress. Zeno won't endorse me if I can't find a breakthrough.

Windsong: They have become more and more radical and desperate lately. First, they sent those researchers here to conduct their haphazard studies, and now, an armed force.

Windsong: And all this effort just to chase the rumor of some source of "perpetual energy"?

Windsong: "That this perpetual energy source must be hidden somewhere beneath the permafrost!"

Windsong: The higher-ups call the shots. All they need to do is spread a little honey in the right places. Then all the little researchers will swarm on it like flies.

Windsong: But could there really be a magical power source like that?

Windsong: Whether there is or not, I still have a map to finish. There's no way that I can map every ley line in the region all by myself.

Windsong: ...

Windsong: Goodbye research funds, goodbye lectures and seminars, and so long to my dreams of being chair of the "Geographical Perspectives" forum.

She jostles the heaps of books, moving them just enough to let in some light and sound.

They seep in through the cracks like starlight.

???: Took-took!

Windsong: ...!

The door snaps shut. Windsong stands against it nervously.

Instruments roll off the table, colliding with each other on the windowsill, the corners, and under the bed, falling in a cacophonous disarray.

Windsong: What was that?

The door is gently pushed open again, revealing the curious face of a sunflower peeking in through the crack.

Avgust: Ms. Windsong, we've been waiting for you!

As far as medals go, the design is a little cruder than expected, and damp paper doesn't quite have the same gravitas as gold or silver.

Still, Windsong has fantasized countless times about receiving such an accolade for her work, even a paper one.

Windsong: ...!

Nina: Ms. Windsong, we prepared a special medal ceremony for you and Avgust!

Pasono: Please come to our ceremony!

Pyotr: ...

Pyotr: We just wanted to thank you for teaching us.

Pyotr: Ms. Vila was right. We shouldn't have been so quick to argue. We should have listened!

Nina: So you should be given an award for being right!

Nina: But our ceremony will not be as big as the ones on TV.

Indeed, this is a very special and exclusive reward.

Simple as it is, it comes with something nothing else could: the innocence and laughter of children.

Pyotr: Ms. Windsong, will you accept this medal?

For the first time in a long while, the study of ley lines basks in the glow of scholarly acclaim.

The paper medal is cupped in her trembling hands.

Windsong: ...

Windsong: I have no cup to put this medal in, so we can't toast with it in celebration.

She sniffles.

Windsong: But now I know, no matter what, I won't be returning empty-handed. Thank you, kids.

Nina: Do you mean, are you leaving us?

Pasono: But there is so much you still need to teach us!

Pyotr: "Rayashki embraces every guest," including you, Ms. Windsong—don't you like it here?

The children are on the verge of tears. She is pulled in helplessly, too.

Windsong: But those things I heard at the welcome ceremony ... Won't we all be leaving soon?

Avgust: No! I don't believe it. That stranger was mean; he wasn't our friend!

Pyotr: Hmph. This is our town; they can't speak for us.

Nina: That's right!

Neither doubt nor sorrow will dim their eyes—before her lies only a sea of steadfast faces.

Their words encouraging and powerful despite their youth.

They plant some strange seed of hope within her.

Pyotr: Ms. Vila "invited" the man from Zeno to leave his ship. Then they went into Mr. Evgeni's meeting room together.

Nina: Uncle Knut promised me that no one will give up this place.

Nina: They will go to many meetings and find "a solution that satisfies both sides."

Avgust: The tortoises move slowly. They need to keep their eyes opened and look for a better answer!

Nina: So will you stay and teach us?

Pyotr: I won't cause you any more trouble, I promise!

The children burst into laughter.

Their voices very nearly drown out the rustling noises coming from the windowsill.

Avgust: Mm? Comrade Calculator is speaking!

Curiosity propels the child through the half-open door of the guest room.

Avgust: Hello!

"Ley Calibrator": ...

Avgust: Comrade Calculator, are you giving the earthworms directions?

The clamor by the window crescendos.

Even on tiptoes, the child barely reaches the faintly glowing calibrator.

Unfortunately, he is not the only one reaching for it.

???: *roars*

More unfortunate still, scaly claws prove mightier than little fingers.

"Ley Calibrator": *cracks*

The other children notice the tug-of-war and crowd around Windsong, squeezing into the increasingly cramped room.

Windsong: What's going on here? Ah, my calibrator!

???: *chews*

Windsong: The whale-like backbone, the diamond-shaped teeth, two short legs, with dim eyes, and an extremely sharp nose. That must be a Kikituk!

Kikituk: *gasps*

Windsong: But their closest habitat should be Kong Karls Land, hundreds of kilometers away.

Its snout fixates on the new treat in Windsong's grasp.

She pulls out the scanner, its gears whining as ley lines flood forth.

Windsong: Their marks on the map appear to be red, sort of reddish brown, and there's a large amount of ley energy accumulated around them. Clearly, they're high on the food chain.

Windsong: Seems like the "small fish" have attracted more than one "big fish."

With a swift kick, she sends the grinning critter tumbling.

Windsong: Kids, get behind me!

The undeterred Kikituks close in on the narrow ledge.

Kikituk: *hissing*

Avgust: Oh, oh! The Kikituks are giving a performance!

Avgust: Their nose sings, their fur dances, and their belly shakes.

Avgust: Mm?

Avgust: But why aren't their ears doing anything?

Windsong: Avgust! What are you doing there? Stay back; those are not Qiqirn!

Avgust: But, but ...

The meaning of both their messages is lost in the confusion.

Avgust: But, but their ears are left behind. They-they can't join the dance.

Avgust: Then they will not get their Alenka!

Windsong: Ears?

Windsong, struck by her sudden revelation, fixes on the Kikituk's head.

Beneath its tufts of plush fur lie well-hidden ears of a deeper color.

Windsong: Природа это числа и черты.

After a brief incantation, lines converge in a beam that hits precisely on its ear.

Kikituk: *wails*

The creature's cry pierces the air.

Windsong: So that seems to be their weak spot.

Windsong: Good job, little one. You're even more perceptive than I thought!

Windsong pats Avgust's head.

Windsong: Next ...

She reveals a dark and dangerous smile.

Windsong: Hmph.

The Kikituks finally relinquish their ill-gotten gains, leaping down and away from the windowsill.

Leaving behind gnawed wet fragments of the ley calibrator.

Windsong: S**t! This was one of the last working instruments I had.

A sunflower gently pats against Windsong's shoulder.

Avgust: Don't be sad, Ms. Windsong.

Avgust: If we plant them in the soil, many more will come out when spring comes.

Windsong: Heh. Thank you, Avgust.

Pyotr: Ms. Windsong, can I be a ley hunter too?

Nina: If we were as good as you are, maybe we could've protected your machine.

Pyotr: And maybe we could protect our town.

Windsong turns her head, meeting many pairs of expectant eyes.

Windsong: Kids, ley hunting isn't a good profession.

Windsong: If you become a ley hunter, you will have to deal with doubt from all your peers, even hatred, and homework that piles up to your roof.

Nina: Ms. Windsong, people in Rayashki are taught not to doubt or hate others. They would never hate you, or us!

Pyotr: Exactly!

The children of Rayashki are in some ways so strange to her.

Their courage and solidarity overcome her long-standing hesitation.

Windsong: ...

Her curiosity at them, at all of this, becomes a palpable force.

One pulling her ever closer to Rayashki.

8#1

The Ode of Factory

FR-08

Children's Square, Rayashki

Nina: I'm happy that you let us show you around, Ms. Windsong.

Nina: We haven't had many other visitors here since the critters started coming near the town.

Avgust: I met a blind lady once. She always smiles, and she has a pretty typewriter. Vila said she's a "writer."

Avgust: The writer has been to many towns, and she fills up her papers with so much ink, just like I do! So, I made a drawing for her, too.

Nina: And she promised us that she will tell more people to come visit Rayashki!

Pyotr: Will people from other places like it here?

Images bounce around in Avgust's mind, just out of grasp.

Windsong: What about your other visitors?

Avgust: I remember they had green and red rectangular paper and some shiny cookies in their hands.

Pyotr: They tried to trade us their silly paper so they could take our cans and things. They never wanted to work with their own hands.

Pyotr: And Rayashki doesn't like lazybones!

On this, the children's heads bob in agreement.

Windsong: ...

Nina: Ms. Windsong, Pyotr got all of us together last night, and we read through our "how to be a good tour guide" guide. So we can guide you!

Pyotr: Ms. Windsong is just a bit strange. She's not lazy!

The child hides his face, but the blush on his cheeks reaches up to his ears.

Avgust: This time, I want borscht, blinchik, and oladyi!

Pasono: Ahem, let's not hurry on to our rewards, Avgust. We haven't helped Ms. Windsong yet.

Avgust: Oh, right.

Figures, large and small, pass deftly through the once tightly-sealed iron door,

arriving at the only factory left, whose lock has not yet rusted over.

Factory, Rayashki

Knut: Good to see you at our little factory, Ms. Windsong!

Windsong: Hello, sir.

Knut: The kids have told me that you want to learn more about the history of Rayashki and the strange things that have happened in the past, yes?

Windsong: I do. But would that be going against any rules?

Knut: Most certainly not, miss. We're not some stubborn old goats that dismiss people for asking questions.

He strides forward.

Knut: In fact, I'm relieved—it will be much easier to talk to you than that bitter fellow from Zeno.

Knut: He came to the factory with his armed squad, took a quick look around, and left even without a polite farewell.

Knut: Like a whiff of cold breeze, that one.

Knut: These old, out-dated machines and hundreds of workers, young and old, each one a mouth to be fed.

Knut: They are certainly not a pretty sight to the eyes of that greedy hyena. Hmph!

Windsong: A pathetic number-crunching cretin.

The whispered insult creeps up to her listener's ear.

Knut: Hahahaha! I'm starting to like you, miss! We would have much to talk about, perhaps over a drink, if only I didn't have to get on with my work!

A curious look around goes beyond the hard-laboring workers.

Tightly sealed doors and a thick layer of dust on aging machinery paint a less than optimistic picture.

Knut: You can see what's going on here, right?

Knut: Don't feel sorry for us. Zeno might no longer need this ore processing factory, but we can make use of what's left of it.

Knut: Once we get rid of the critters, we can arrange for other minerals or materials to be shipped to Rayashki for processing!

He rubs his hands together, leaning against the shell of a rusted machine.

Knut: It is a shame we've wasted so much of our good years, never preparing for these bad times.

Knut: If those strange little monsters weren't there, we might be able to return to our mines. Ah, then, we'd really be able to turn things around.

Windsong: About these mining sites ...

Her notebook flutters rapidly, its pages turning as fast as a rolling flame.

Windsong: Mr. Knut, have you ever found anything there? Other than runium ore?

Knut: Hmm.

Knut: Never! I know those sites like the back of my own hand. I've never seen any other minerals of any worth there.

The rugged man seems to catch her disappointment, and far quicker than she'd expect.

Knut: But give it some time, miss. Well, give me some time.

Knut: Just a few months ago, back when Zeno was still keen to work with us and not just ship us away, I remember they found some strange little pebbles.

Knut: Dark pebbles that were stuck in the claws of those little monsters.

Knut: Zeno soon sent out some troops and caught all the monsters. They didn't leave a single one behind.

Windsong: ...!

Knut: We never heard about those pebbles again, nor have we found more of them in the mines.

Knut: And you know the rest. Now we've exhausted the runium, and more and more strange-looking critters have appeared. So it's not safe to go back there. We left them completely deserted.

Windsong: Please take a look at this, Mr. Knut.

Windsong sketches fervently as Knut lumbers towards her with a curious eye.

Knut: No, no, their claws were thicker than a polar bear's.

Knut: Ah! But these are closer!

Knut: These monsters had much larger teeth. They almost looked like old mining picks.

Knut: And no ears!

Windsong: Could they be some kind of Hoituk?

Knut: Yes! This one looks just like the creatures!

Windsong: If that's true, then it may be another "big fish" that has come here to feed.

Knut: It is true! You can ask around. Many of the other workers have seen it.

Windsong: So, the color of a Hoituk is bright yellow, and that matches with these bright yellow lines I've traced here on the map.

Windsong: They are burrowing animals, often living as deep as 50 meters underground. So if they were here, that must mean ...

Windsong: That there must be some undiscovered resource here.

The corners of her mouth curl as she mutters the words.

Knut: Talk of undiscovered resources would be music to our ears, miss.

Windsong: Ahem. I don't want to get your hopes up. It's still too early to draw any conclusions.

Knut: Hahaha! Yet, the corner of your mouth is suggesting the opposite!

Windsong: I must be cautious before confirming there really is a new resource!

Windsong: Nonetheless, it's a silver lining. Thank you, Mr. Knut.

Knut: Think nothing of it, miss! Maybe one day, you and your research will return the favor.

Windsong: I will, if I can.

She reaches out a hand, and he shakes it heartily with warm strength.

Windsong: I hope your work here can be resumed shortly.

Knut: Don't worry about us! We will find a way to drive those critters away and start production once again.

Knut: We have all our brothers and sisters with us, and these machines still run perfectly.

Knut: As long as we continue to put in our best effort, there is no reason why things won't get better.

He pats the trembling, coughing machines with affection, like embracing an old friend.

Windsong: Is this exceptionally positive spirit common with the people here?

Knut: Well, can't blame us for that! There are very few places in the world like Rayashki.

Knut: Here, everyone earns their food and their rest through working hard together. Then, outside of work—ice hockey, learning courses, even music lessons—not everyone is as lucky as us.

Knut: That is why we won't let Rayashki die.

Knut's voice rises as if singing.

Knut: With busy hands and open hearts, Rayashki will live on.

Knut: It will grow stronger, glowing as brightly as these furnaces!

Something brilliant indeed burns within those furnaces.

A product greater than any ore or slag, emerging from the melding of purpose and sweat.

Windsong: ...

The pen that stopped stirs once again.

But this time, she seems to be sketching out something far harder to picture.

Windsong: I have to say, Rayashki is truly a curious place.

Windsong mutters to herself.

Windsong: It has a spirit which I've never found elsewhere.

Windsong: Yes. Perhaps that's what was missing from the study of ley lines in the past.

gurgle

An odd sound interrupts her contemplation.

The sunflower pats against the boy's belly.

Avgust: Ms. Windsong, would you like to meet Mr. Patrik?

The friendly bear Knut nods with an understanding smile.

Knut: It's time to go to the canteen, boys and girls. Eat well, and you'll grow strong!

Knut: Patrik knows how to feed you well. He's the best cook in town.

Knut: But I would suggest you be careful with that one, if you don't want to get stuck with his endless chatter all night.

Windsong: I have never been to the canteen. I stayed out of that area in my previous "visits" to avoid unwanted trouble.

Avgust: Heh-heh! Forward, to Comrade Blinchik!

Knut: All the best, miss! I look forward to hearing good news from you.

Knut waves them off before settling back into his world of metal.

The churning and wheezing of machinery replacing words.

The canteen buzzes with the din of workers.

The children weave through the busy hall, leading Windsong by the hand.

Canteen, Rayashki

Avgust: This is our canteen.

Avgust: We play hide-and-seek here when we're hungry.

Avgust: Comrades Stew and Potato Piroshki are always the easiest to find!

Avgust: They are not very clever at hiding!

Avgust: But Comrade Blinchik is very good at the game. He can only be found at dinners on Friday.

Windsong: ...

Nina: We have good food, like mashed potatoes, and boiled potatoes, and potato stew!

Nina: Mr. Patrik said a good cook can turn even simple ingredients into delicious food!

Nina casts a glance around her before she speaks softly.

Nina: The grown-ups are so kind to us. Sometimes they give us their cheese and salad, so they only have potatoes to eat.

Pyotr: Don't cry, Nina. Remember when you shared your Alenka with everyone?

Pyotr: When we grow up, it'll be our turn to help the grown-ups with their potatoes!

There is an awareness in them, a gravity few children possess at their age.

Thankfully, some do retain their blissful innocence.

Avgust: We also have the tin-hat festival, when they gave us metal hats with food in them!

Windsong: ...?

Pyotr: Avgust, it's called the Worker's Festival.

Pyotr: We have it every month. Everyone must sit in a circle in the canteen and sing songs, and Ms. Vila plays the accordion for us.

Pyotr: We each get a can with food in it. Sometimes it's tushonka, sometimes it's salad, sometimes sprats.

Avgust: Yes, and after the tin-hat festival, we would bury our tin-hats in the ground. Yellow ones, red ones, and white ones. Then tiny trees will come out from them next year!

Pyotr: I have told you many times! They are not tin seeds, and they don't grow into trees! They are just tin cans! We only bury them so they won't pollute the snow.

The subject of their debate flips a hidden switch in Windsong's mind. The revelation flicking into light.

Windsong: Piles of tin cans ... Food ...

She unfolds the ley energy map, pointing to the last blurred area of interwoven lines and traces.

Windsong: Those empty cans you mentioned—did you store them here?

Pasono: Oh, I know this place. That's where the adults dug a big hole; they put some things inside. It's covered up with rocks and ice now.

Nina: Yes, Pasono is right! That's where the grown-ups put all our old metal after they make them into little cubes!

Nina: Ms. Vila said it helps keep our town and the whole region clean.

Nina: Why, what's wrong with that place?

Windsong: ...!

Windsong: I'm thrilled! There must be lots of "big fish" left to be found around there!

Windsong: If I can write a report and provide a practical plan, maybe I can get Ze- ... I mean, I could request reinforcements!

She halts, swallowing back the unfriendly name.

Kids: Yay! School trip! School trip!

Windsong: This is no trip, children! I'm not going there for a hike! You must stay in town and be good. That goes for every one of you! Understood?

Her resolution fails before she even finishes.

The children's protests rise in a disordered chorus, drowning out all other surrounding sounds.

Only to be matched by the static fizz of an announcement.

Bertolt: Ahem!

Windsong clutches at a thin straw of salvation.

Windsong: Shh. Quiet, kids!

Bertolt: Attention please. Tomorrow, at 8 in the morning, we will be holding our final hearing.

Bertolt: In this meeting, we hope to finalize our next steps and answer any remaining questions. We look forward to seeing you there.

8#1

Heavier Than Knowledge

FR-09

Meeting Room, Rayashki

Bertolt leans back in his armchair, casting a fleeting glance forward before his head falls.

Bertolt: What's this? Are you planning on getting a job with Zeno, too?

Windsong: ...?

Bertolt: It says here you've been staying in this town for months, but it seems you're not on our list for "Potential Recruitment from Rayashki."

The smile on his face remains as affably saccharine as ever.

Bertolt: I should remind you, for you researchers, what you produce tells much more about you than your "efforts."

Windsong: That's precisely why I'm here.

Bertolt: Go on.

He finally deigns to raise his head up.

Windsong: Based on the recent investigations, I'm confident that there is a new energy source in the area that has yet to be discovered.

Bertolt: ...

Bertolt: And that's it? We already believed there was something here when we sent you out in the first place!

Bertolt: You were sent here to find it. Instead, all you do is confirm what we already knew.

Windsong: But you said that "perpetual energy" was just a myth, didn't you?

Bertolt: O-of course, it wasn't "just a myth," lady. Why else would we ask you to investigate here in the first place?

Windsong gives a frown that slips, quite intentionally, into a scowl.

Bertolt: Do you have anything else to report?

Windsong: No, but I do need your help. I will need an armed squad to come with me to the mining sites so that I can continue my investigations into this subject.

Windsong: I'm afraid I don't know how long it will take. It also depends on the number of soldiers you can spare for the task.

Bertolt: Aha!

Bertolt: You have a terrible sense of humor.

Windsong: I'm not being funny. You want more research on the new resource too, don't you?

Bertolt: Ms. Windsong, do you really think this is even a remotely reasonable request?

Bertolt: Critters are running rampant in the area, and you demand help to verify what is, as far as I can see, a highly questionable conclusion. Why should I waste Zeno's time and resources on this?

Bertolt: Not to mention putting the lives of our soldiers at risk.

Windsong: If you have doubts, please take a look at these files.

The researcher dives her hands into her bag but is met with a wave of dismissal.

Bertolt: And let me guess, you learned all this from your "study of ley lines"?

Windsong: I ...

Bertolt: To date, the theory of ley lines has neither been approved by the "Arcane Study Review Association," nor accepted by the "Project Assessment of Human Science and Technology." It has zero academic achievements, zero endorsements, and aside from the questionable example in front of me—zero researchers.

Windsong: That's all only a temporary setback.

Bertolt: Ms. Windsong, I sympathize with the awkward situation I have put you in. However, Zeno simply cannot afford to waste resources on a proposal without any solid evidence.

Windsong: I will give you something; all I need is a bit of help upfront. I promise!

The look in his eyes is glazed, bored, but Windsong does not falter.

Windsong: Did you not come here to deal with these critters? Then what's the fuss about? Can't you deal with them while accompanying me to these mining sites as well?

Bertolt's eyes widen, now unglazed, as he rises.

He paces silently, drifting at first, then proceeding to the windowsill.

Bertolt: I'm afraid you've got our intentions altogether wrong.

The windows close tightly, sealing the last whispers of wind from the outside.

Bertolt: Zeno is here for one thing only: a source of perpetual energy.

Bertolt: This is what you have been tasked to find, with the resources you were given. We won't approve any further requests until you have a solid lead. We aren't paying you for a charity mission.

Windsong: ...!

Windsong: So, then, you never planned on controlling the critters here. The squad you brought here was to control the town?!

Bertolt: A force sufficient to deal with critters would have attracted unwanted attention from our rivals. It is not in our interests to share this town or its resources. I'm sure you can see that.

Windsong: So, even if we do find the resource for you, you won't leave this town or its people alone.

Bertolt: We're talking about the ultimate energy source of arcanum. Do you think we will just walk away and leave it to be squandered by a bunch of ignorant peasants and miners?

Windsong: You should be ashamed of yourself!

Bertolt's smile fades like a bad aftertaste.

Bertolt: What we're going to do with Rayashki should be of no concern to you. We have made every arrangement for them.

Bertolt: We aren't monsters. Before the final decision is made, we will continue to help the locals as much as we can.

Bertolt: Including you.

Before the wild-eyed researcher can voice her dissent, Bertolt steers the conversation with well-practiced ease.

Wordlessly, he draws out an attractive-looking document and slides it across the table toward her.

Windsong: Is this ...?!

Bertolt: You seem surprised. Isn't it what you have always wanted?

Bertolt: With Zeno's endorsement, you will be able to teach your program in any university.

Windsong: ...

Bertolt: We have prepared this gesture of our good faith in you.

Bertolt: Now it's your turn to show yours. Forget about an armed squad. They have more important things to do.

Bertolt: You're on your own, my friend. But prove to us that you can do this job, and bring us the best answer you can give.

The pale letterhead stings Windsong's fingertips.

Bertolt: And this piece of paper will be yours when you complete your mission.

Windsong: I understand.

Bertolt: See that you do. Good luck out there, Ms. Windsong.

Deep footprints, now half-buried in fresh snow, trace the path of the researcher's determined march behind her.

Abandoned Mine, Rayashki

Her courage, passion, and body temperature rapidly cooling against the blizzard.

Windsong: Was I out of my mind?!

Windsong: He was just trying to get me out of his office. He threw a carrot out of the window, and I chased right after it like a blinded mule!

Windsong: Still ...

Her hand lingers on the paper nestled within her pocket.

Windsong: Maybe this "carrot" is too good to let go.

With a sigh of resignation, she reaches deeper.

Windsong: Focus. Once I fill the gaps in my data, I will be able to pitch it to Zeno, and all subsequent research won't be a problem anymore!

Windsong: The primary food sources for Hoituk are raw minerals underground. Those processed metals only keep them from starving to death. They wouldn't have gone across any icy ocean just to gnaw on old equipment and trash.

Windsong: All I need to do is find a trace of their activities so that I can learn about their current conditions and, from there, locate their other food sources.

Windsong: Stay calm. Hoituk are gentle creatures. They rarely attack humans. I just need to be cautious.

Her internal struggles will have to wait, as more practical problems loom larger.

The blizzard has covered almost everything, leaving a few cans to poke out, rattling along with the wind.

Windsong: Crazy! Whoa!

Windsong: Alright, change of direction.

Windsong: If I were to look down instead of looking forward, maybe I should scan the area and follow where the ley energy is leading. Just like I did at Silbury Hill.

Windsong: Ahem! Of course, I hope the outcome will be different this time.

She surveys the expanse of boundless snow.

Windsong: Before all that, I need to clear out this place.

Windsong: Природа это числа и черты.

Windsong: Природа это мозаика цветов.

The soil churns in slurry waves along the seashore, a mix of mud, snow, and stone.

A violent resonance spreads beyond it, one to which she is completely unaware.

Hoituk?: *hiss*

Clearly, these creatures harbor some discontent at these scars on their land.

Windsong: Shoot! Now I've done it.

Windsong: Those vestigial digging teeth, the three-fingers-long tearing teeth—these are not Hoituk!

Hoituk?: *hiss*

They bare their teeth and claws in a rhythmic way, like a primitive pre-feeding ritual.

Windsong: These scaled wings must be for swimming. Then you must be ...

Windsong: Mutant Kikituk from the Olga area!

Windsong: ...

Windsong: You should be at the Olga Strait, hunting for migrating salmon and whales, not here!

Mutant Kikituk: *roars*

The Kikituks can no longer contain themselves and pounce towards Windsong.

Windsong sits slumped on the ground, gasping for air.

Their fury has not yet abated; the creatures hold their ground.

Windsong: ...

Windsong: Why would you come here? What inspired you to trek across the ocean, just to hunt for humans?

Her aggressors show no signs of understanding.

They inch closer, drool drooping from their mouths.

Windsong: D**n it! It seems, while their claws and teeth have degraded, their reflexes much quicker than a Hoituk's.

Windsong: They perceived my approach, even though I used my ley line reader as a dampener.

A rumble, distant then near, drowns out her sigh.

A gunshot hammers out nearby, the shot landing on one of the snarling Kikituk.

The bolt is drawn back. The familiar sound sends another scurrying away.

Windsong: ...!

Evgeni: Get out!

Evgeni: Get out of here! I'll cover you!

More gunfire thunders, over and over, until the last Kikituk abandons their position.

Windsong: Thank you, sir.

Composing herself, the researcher immediately returns to her work.

Windsong: Evgeni, the kids told me about a can pile. Is it nearby?

Evgeni: Can pile?

He furrows his brow, motioning with his eyes to some hilly snowdrifts nearby.

Evgeni: They must be talking about our waste metal. I'm afraid it's gone, Ms. Windsong. Maybe animals dug it all out, or maybe those little monsters ate it.

Windsong: Do you know if that happened before or after the runium mines ran dry?

Evgeni: I'm not sure.

Evgeni's brow furrows again, this time casting a surveying glance at her scattered instruments.

Evgeni: You shouldn't be here. There's nothing of value to find in this place.

Evgeni: And you're not supposed to be using this arcane equipment here, either.

Evgeni: We have a better way to deal with these fierce little monsters. What you're doing will just attract more of them.

His statement rattles her.

Windsong: You can drive away the Kikituks?!

Evgeni: Not anymore. We don't have much left to fight them off with. Zeno didn't bring any equipment for our team, let alone any weapons.

Evgeni: Go. Leave before it's too late.

He carefully checks the rifle in his hand.

Windsong: What if I don't want to just give up?

Evgeni slows down, making his inspection come across as even more deliberate.

Evgeni: I've seen your residence application. You say you are a researcher.

Evgeni: Then you should be clever enough not to go down a fruitless and dangerous path.

Windsong: I admit that what I'm doing here is reckless, and maybe I'm just motivated by my own selfish interests. But I can't just walk away from my commitments.

Windsong: You have lived in Rayashki for a long time. You know what "commitment" means here much better than I do.

There is a shift in his face as he turns away from her.

Windsong: I won't give it up so easily, just like the people here won't give away their land like nothing.

Evgeni: It's stubbornness. That's all.

Windsong: ...?

Evgeni: They should have gone to other places and put their talents to good use, rather than staying here to fight for nothing.

Windsong holds a stare, lifting her chin to match up to him.

Windsong: Is that why you gave away the town so easily to Zeno? Do you really even know your neighbors?

Evgeni: I have lived and worked together with them for decades. Don't be ridiculous. I just ...

Evgeni: I agree with Zeno's perspective.

Windsong: Tsk. I've been to many places, and I have encountered many people like you—stuck-up "leader types," making decisions on behalf of other people because "it's what's good for them."

Evgeni: And they should listen. Just as you should now.

He braces the rifle as he motions her back and scans the near horizon.

Evgeni: It's my responsibility to protect everyone, to do right by them.

Evgeni: I will make them see it tomorrow at the hearing.

Windsong: Ah!

8#1

The Only Days Left

FR-10

People's Square, Rayashki

People stream in from all directions.

They stand now at the crossroads of the town's fate.

Bertolt: *clears throat* People of Rayashki, my dear friends, good day to you all.

Bertolt: Over the past two days, Zeno has assessed the potential risks and benefits in the area, and held hearings on what should be done about the future of this town.

Bertolt: Our hearings saw very limited attendance. We've taken that to be a gesture of approval.

Bertolt: Mr. Evgeni has put in a great effort helping to make these changes happen. We all owe him a great deal. Thank you, sir.

He motions to Evgeni at his side.

A freshly printed document unfurls before all present, Zeno's seal stamped deliberately in the most prominent position.

Bertolt: Please believe that we have made the best decision we could for you.

Bertolt: We all know the runium here has run dry, and the land has been exhausted of all further material wealth, now and into the foreseeable future.

Bertolt: As a result, your local processing factory has lost its intended purpose.

Bertolt: What's more, Zeno has changed our cooperation strategy. Though your town's loyalty will never be forgotten, we must have a sober-minded view of its costs and benefits.

Bertolt: To sum up, our final decision is that ...

Bertolt: We will be ending operations and all future cooperation between Zeno and Rayashki.

A heavy hammer swings in the square, producing a whistling wind.

Knut: Well, Mr. Bertolt, you have just got here; perhaps you didn't have enough time to get to know us well enough. Rayashki's value is not just in our runium. We have many other factories, too.

Urgent words of protest flood in from all sides.

Bertolt: Yes, you have a brick factory, a power plant, many forklifts, a smattering of conveyor belts. But all these were all built and suited for only the processing of runium ore.

Bertolt: Without the ore, they simply have no benefit to us.

Residents: ...

The crowd murmurs, voices bubbling up and simmering like boiling water.

Bertolt raps the table, ending the broil.

Bertolt: Now that you have full knowledge of the situation and our intentions, we want to assure you that your loyalty has not been forgotten, so we have generously prepared two choices for the future of Rayashki.

The assembly hushes.

Bertolt: Firstly, Zeno believes that you have many valuable qualities. The determination and skills you've shown in the past year of our cooperation have proved that your people can be a great asset to us.

Bertolt scans across the faces looking back at him.

Bertolt: Indeed, many of you already meet the entrance requirements to join Zeno.

Bertolt: Therefore, on behalf of Zeno Arms Academy, I wish to extend a heartfelt invitation to you.

Bertolt: Leave Rayashki. Join us and work for one of our other branches as members of Zeno.

Knut: What are you saying!? You want us to abandon our home for some promise of a job?

Bertolt: Calm down, Mr. Knut. This is not about abandoning your home. It's about joining us in our efforts to contribute to world peace. Through a more optimized allocation of manpower.

Resident I: So you're just going to pack us all up and ship us away to work for Zeno?

Bertolt: You misunderstand, madam.

He closes the folder, looking conspicuously towards the children beside Windsong.

Bertolt: Every year, Zeno dismisses 4% of our employees because they failed to pass our rigorous work reviews. And the number of our colleagues that are killed in the line of duty is even larger still.

Bertolt: Working for Zeno is a privilege, not a gift.

Bertolt: That's why only a small number of you will be allowed to come and work for us.

Resident II: What?

Bertolt: Now, according to Article 58 in the section on "protection of arcanist rights" signed at the Event Horizon Convention ...

Bertolt: We will provide basic supplies for any residents who haven't been offered a position with Zeno. They will be transferred immediately to the nearest relief station until our social workers contact them for further arrangements.

Knut: So then, you're suggesting you will send our children and elderly away to some kind of refugee station?

Knut: And the rest of us must go to work for Zeno without any questions?

Knut: You ****! This is total rubbish!

He waves off, then pushes aside the Zeno soldier in front of him.

Zeno Soldier: Sir, please lower your voice.

Bertolt: Well. You would be glad to know that your work experience in particular is valuable to Zeno, Mr. Knut.

He attempts a pat on Knut's shoulder, who shrugs him off.

But Bertolt acts entirely unfazed, unfolding the document further.

Bertolt: If you're not interested in our first plan, we have another.

Bertolt: If the residents in the area prove reluctant to relocate, Zeno can offer another alternative. As stated earlier, Rayashki is a remote town that possesses some significant industrial infrastructure.

Bertolt: Therefore, it could be considered an ideal location for a new complex of arms factories.

Vila: ...!

Bertolt: There would be a need to substantially upgrade the Rayashki wharf. To turn it into one of the seaports Zeno plans to build across the globe.

Bertolt: Additionally, a radio station will be constructed within the town.

Bertolt: Which will better facilitate our communication throughout the Arctic region so as to stabilize and coordinate with other powers in the area.

Bertolt: ...

Bertolt: We will now be passing out forms, listing the options I've presented. Please fill them in with your choice.

Vila: So your only other option is to turn Rayashki into some kind of military base under Zeno's control?

Bertolt: I won't put it so bluntly, but you're not incorrect.

Bertolt: Our resources, as much as anyone's, are limited, and they must be put to good use. We cannot afford to waste them on strategically usele- ... costly people and places.

Bertolt: If you want Zeno to help you, you should be able to give us something in return, don't you agree?

He folds the proposal again with satisfaction.

The crowd heaves in protest, held at bay by the soldiers around Bertolt.

Knut: So, Evgeni, this is "the best choice" you made for all of us?

Bertolt: Ahem! I must speak in Mr. Evgeni's defense. He is committed to his duty and only wishes to do what he can for his compatriots.

Knut: Shameless! All you've done is sold us out!

Resident I: You tell them, Knut!

Resident II: Do you think it's getting a bit windy lately? Clearly, with all the hot air in Evgeni's head, his mind has been blown away!

Countless eyes fall on Evgeni. Disappointment, sadness—perhaps something more complex.

Evgeni: ...

Evgeni: I swear to you, I am not doing this out of my own interest.

Evgeni: Comrades, there are many better places in this world, and you have better purposes to fulfill.

Evgeni: You shouldn't waste your time here.

Knut: Bah!

The bear of a man puffs up with anger.

Bertolt: Let's all calm down, my friends! It's time to be reasonable!

Bertolt: Think carefully. Zeno has been very generous regarding the offers before you.

He readies himself, as if about to launch into a grand prepared speech, but his hand trembles.

A chill wind sweeps over him.

Vila: Generous? Now that's ridiculous!

Vila: We won't let you take away our family and friends, nor are we about to let you turn our town into a puppet state!

Resident II: We will stay here! No matter what!

Evgeni: Comrades, I understand how you feel right now.

Evgeni: But we must face the cruel reality of our situation.

Vila: And you're willing to send away our own people or give up on all we've built here because of this so-called "reality."

Evgeni: It is the only way forward.

Evgeni: If we continue to stay here without any help, it will be the end of us either way.

Vila: Do we have to turn to Zeno for this help?

Evgeni fails to react at first, but a defeated expression comes over him.

Evgeni: The truth is, just as Rayashki's economy has been dependent on runium, we remain dependent on Zeno.

Evgeni: Without them, at the present rate of consumption, we will be out of supplies and materials within a year.

Vila: ...

A silent tidal shift sweeps over those assembled.

The researcher observes the change with harsh recognition.

Windsong: This situation looks bad.

Windsong: Zeno is determined to gain control over this place.

She touches the unsealed letter. Her fingers jump away, as if it had been electrified.

Windsong: ...

Windsong: But if I complete the task as Zeno requested, does it mean ...

Bertolt's words echo in her ears.

Windsong: I will shatter their dream?

Windsong: And what about my dream?

The words stick in her throat.

Windsong: Did the people who refused to acknowledge the study of ley lines act out of the same self-interest?

Windsong: I've seen this happen so many times before.

Windsong: A simple dream is made to face a cruel reality. Where the clever ones give up and leave, and the stubborn fools remain, waiting to be crushed.

Windsong: "We asked for our misery."

She turns, her mixed feelings refusing to settle.

The wall of soldiers has suppressed most of the dissent in the square.

But still, some bravely charge forward.

Vila: Wait!

Vila: I'm not finished.

Bertolt dismisses her with his hand as he leaves the stage.

Bertolt: But I am, Ms. Vila.

The researcher remains stunned, but this potent chemistry of hope and resolve begins to catalyze something in her.

Windsong: ...

Windsong: ...

Windsong: Sir! With all due respect. I can't complete this task alone.

Windsong: As an ordinary researcher, I can relate to them. Please forgive me for interrupting.

She lifts her head proudly, looking out in the direction of the crowd.

Windsong: I have heard so much about Rayashki these days.

Windsong: They started from nothing, but bit by bit, they accomplished the impossible.

Windsong: Their voice should be heard.

Windsong: Природа это числа и черты.

The soil and snow under her feet becomes imbued with new life, rising up around her.

They clamp onto military boots and surge up and into gun barrels, plugging them up in a comical fashion.

Zeno Soldier: ...?!

Vila: ...!

The teacher seizes on this opportunity.

She climbs over the wall of confused soldiers and charges forward.

Zeno Soldier: Miste- ... Mister Bertolt.

Zeno Soldier: We can't hold them any longer!

Their conflict ceases.

Scaly palms forcefully grab Bertolt's arm, sharp nails tearing at his sleeve.

Vila: Now, will you listen to me?

A clean, new ledger is stuffed into Bertolt's hands.

Vila: We don't need your help. Your soldiers and your tyranny are no longer welcome here.

Bertolt: ...

Vila turns around to face her people.

Vila: Comrades, what do you say? Shall we solve the problem with the strength of our own hands and hearts?

Evgeni: ...

Knut: What else can we do? This is what we've always done when there was a problem!

Resident I: There will be more solutions than problems if we work together!

Resident II: If I must die, I will die here with all of you!

Knut: Just stop talking nonsense, you idiot! Nobody is going to die!

Vila: Rayashki belongs to all of us. We will stand with it till its last moment!

The sudden surge of conviction and unity cows the guards as they move backwards.

Many blush with shame.

Some of them quietly withdraw.

Windsong: Huh, they might say they're just ordinary people, but they are so brave and noble.

8#1

The Ley Hunter

FR-11

Children's Square, Rayashki

A lonely researcher aimlessly paces through Rayashki's square.

The town's cold wind clearly cannot smooth the wrinkles of her brow.

Windsong: Could I really have traded the future of these people away for my ley line studies?

Windsong: *sighs* Zeno ...

Windsong: I was a mule chasing after a carrot on a stick. They lured me here all so I could help ruin everything!

Her voice bursts up from her chest.

Vila: Heh! You seem to be in a good mood.

Windsong: ...?

Vila: We taught Zeno a lesson. They were forced to leave with their devil's bargains and tails tucked behind them. We fought back, finally.

Vila: A nice little trick, that was. Thank you, Comrade Windsong.

She smiles at Windsong, giving her a wink.

Vila: We all know who the mysterious hero was that gave us a helping hand.

Windsong: I, I didn't do anything.

Vila: It's no shame to have helped your friends, not to mention to stand up to Zeno.

Vila: Have more confidence in yourself, Comrade Windsong.

Windsong: But will you really gain anything from this fight?

Vila: Not sure, but we have to do something, right?

Vila: That's why I'm here.

Windsong: To talk to me?

Windsong: I don't know why, but Ms. Vila, you must have thought too much of me.

Windsong: In fact, I'm only a simple researcher. I'm not powerful enough to change Zeno's decision.

Vila: You are the one thinking too much, Comrade Windsong.

Vila: Your ley line lessons were much more popular than you think. They have had a positive effect on the children.

Vila: Now, they are looking at the bigger picture and observing the world in a more detailed way. You've unleashed their curiosity.

Vila: "Is the aurora the bubbles spit out by the stars? They form such a beautiful map. Do they study ley lines, too?"

Vila feigns distress, shaking her head with a pretended childlike confusion.

Windsong: But it remains the case that the study of ley lines has never been verified.

Windsong: For all its ambitions. Only a limited number of people studied it in the past decades, and that number is decreasing even now.

Vila nods thoughtfully.

Windsong: ...!

Vila: What you are looking at is not some skin problem, but my past.

Vila: My past as a Rusalka.

Windsong: Rusalka? You mean the mermaid from folklore?!

Vila: My people used to live in a far-secluded place in the north, away from the humans.

Vila: For hundreds of years, there was only hostility, plunder, and slaughter between us and them.

Vila: We only started to learn more about each other in the last few decades, and then I was born. It's been a hard life growing up within human society, but I've become used to it.

Vila: Still, some things never got easier.

Vila: Most humans still thought I was a freak. They "welcomed" me with mocking, sarcasm, and contempt for my people, my heritage.

Vila: As for the Rusalki, they too found a half-blooded mermaid unacceptable. They didn't approve of my living among the humans, forcing me to live as a fugitive in Moscow and St. Petersburg.

"Half-blooded." It was a nauseating term, one separating the Rusalki from the "scaleless" humans who had stolen their homeland.

An ancient myth that was the source of the enduring hatred between Rusalki and humans.

Vila: They tried to catch me by every means possible, so they could wash away the "stain" they saw in me.

Windsong: That sounds very difficult.

Vila: Humans have stigmatized and hunted the Rusalki for centuries, while Rusalki still have the instinct to attack and plunder human ships even now.

Vila: How are they supposed to make peace in such little time?

Vila: That was what I thought years ago. Then, I came to this town.

She surveys the white land; the unifying cover of snow removes all distinctions, differences, and flaws.

Vila: "A wonderful world where humans and Rusalki could live in peace." I was finally convinced.

Vila: In Rayashki, everyone can make contributions with their skills, whether you are a human, a Rusalka, or a ley line researcher.

Windsong: ...

Vila: I don't mean to give you more stress or push you. You will always be our friend, whatever your choice is.

Vila: But this is not an unreachable dream. It's real.

A familiar phrase wells up inside her again.

Conjured from a long-silenced past.

School of Ley Lines

Windsong: Haha!

The girl, then much thinner and more stubborn than now, couldn't help but cheer.

The other ley hunters fail to take notice, as they comb through their scattered papers.

Windsong: The editor of the Environmental Research agreed to publish our report, finally!

Windsong: But he only gave us 5000 words.

Windsong: On the last few pages.

Windsong: Undoubtedly, it's still a good start, our first step to reviving the study of ley lines!

Windsong beams with excitement, clumsily sprawling over the table to select from their papers with care.

Dull, dry theories shine anew, bright and vivid in her eyes.

A table of twinkling stars.

Yet, these stars must shine against an all-consuming field of darkness.

Ley Hunter I: That's it. I give up! Maybe I'll study something else, like urban planning, or landscape design.

Ley Hunter I: At least I can make a living that way.

Windsong remains buried in her heap of books and manuscripts, oblivious to the loss.

Ley Hunter II: The study of ley lines is outdated. Everyone agrees now that it can't be verified by science.

Ley Hunter II: "This whole study was a dead end. Ley lines are only a baseless theory of arcanum."

The old papers on the table filled with nothing more than nonsense and wasted ink.

At least that's how the world received it.

Ley Hunter III: I tried talking about our study of ley lines with other arcanists, but almost no one has ever heard of it. They are more interested in Laplace's breakthroughs.

Ley Hunter III: Or anecdotes in their own fields, like the Chaotic Energy sampling mentioned in the paper written by the Butterfly of Lorentz.

The stars have dimmed.

Windsong: So, maybe it is an unreachable dream?

A long moment of wistful distraction falls back into reality.

After much hesitation, she begins to speak again.

Windsong: I do wish I could help, but ...

Windsong: It would take a lot of resources to verify the theory behind ley lines. There may be even danger and sacrifice.

Windsong: Even Zeno has paid little attention to my research. They only see it as a means to an end.

Windsong: Researchers in other fields can stand on the shoulders of giants, while I, I don't even have a school to return to.

Windsong: I doubt that the study of ley lines will help you much.

She retreats a few steps back.

Vila: I see.

Vila: Well, thank you for your honesty, Comrade Windsong.

Vila looks away, holding the regret deep in her chest.

Windsong: I'm sorry.

Vila: I'll see you soon.

Windsong: See you, Vila.

She bows her head and turns, taking a few more difficult steps away.

Perhaps it was her unattainable dream of revival that slowed her, or the weight of all that had gone wrong.

Vila: Wait, Comrade Windsong!

A burst of light steps leaps toward her once more.

Windsong: ...?

Vila: Don't forget your next lesson. The children are still waiting.

Windsong: But the town is ...

Vila: Life must continue, comrade.

Vila: We can't let our worries stop us.

Windsong: Okay.

8#1

The Night Train

FR-12

Classroom, Rayashki

As the chalk marks its final stroke, the lecturer exhales a long breath.

Windsong: Class is over.

Windsong: Thank goodness, I still remembered the basic premises of "Ley Lines and Biology."

Windsong: Feel free to ask me any questions.

Windsong: Cheer up, little ones. There won't be any exams for this subject.

She offers a hesitant joke to ease the awkwardness of the class.

But their usual playful responses never emerge.

Windsong: Mm?

She turns to face a class that must be bored, asleep, maybe distracted. She's met instead by clear and focused eyes.

Avgust: Ms. Windsong, are you going to dig up those potatoes alone again?

Nina: Is there anything we can do to help you?

Nina: Ms. Vila said we will work together to beat the critters out there.

Nina: That we will find their weakness as long as we finish the map with you!

Pyotr: Just like how you taught us to!

Pyotr: "Qiqirn are not dangerous at all. They are plant-eating critters and pose little threat to humans."

Avgust: I have ropes, flowers, and white gloves. We will dig up a lot of potatoes together.

Avgust: Pyotr is strong. He can move any rocks that are in our way. Nina can prepare a kettle of warm water for everyone. And ...

The children's voices rise and fall. What began as icy determination soon melts into a cascade of sobbing tears.

Windsong: I'm sorry, little ones.

Windsong: I wish I could verify all the theories we've been working on, but ...

Pyotr: ...

She affixes Rayashki's ley energy map to the blackboard, circling an empty void.

Windsong: As you can see, a critical part is missing.

Windsong: It might take months to finish it.

Windsong: Besides, there may be even more dangerous critters in that area.

Avgust: Then the town will become the witch's new castle? Or perhaps an empty castle.

Kids: ...

Her attempt to turn the mood again falls flat.

A merciful bell rings out the dreary topic like a dirge.

Thankfully, the next teacher arrives swiftly to relieve her.

Vila: Quiet, children.

She holds her gaze firm, sweeping over the assembled children.

Vila: Wipe your tears and cheer up! Our Rayashki will stand strong!

Pyotr: Really?!

Windsong: But what are you going to do?

Windsong is taken aback at first. Then, contemplating the possibilities, she delicately weighs her words.

Windsong: Vila, I hope you aren't seriously considering Zeno's ...

Vila: Of course not. They might try, but we will never give in!

Vila: No matter what, for now, we must find a way to protect our town. We will need a shelter from these critters.

Vila: We've all decided to stay.

The curtains part, and sunlight pours in from outside.

Vila: Look outside, children.

Vila: Each and every one of us is doing what we can to hold our town together.

Avgust: Knut's factory is spitting out puffy bubbles.

Vila: Heh heh.

Vila: The workers are going to transform the abandoned factories into something useful.

Vila: They are cleaning the ore and debris there. Not an easy job.

Vila: After that, we will start new production lines and cooperate with the surrounding cities. We will grow potatoes, breed fish, and make canned food. We will find our strengths together!

Avgust: Are we putting makeup on the factories? We can paint their faces and put beautiful garlands on them!

Nina: Hmm? So what is Mr. Patrik doing?

Avgust: Everyone's waiting in line. Is it the tin-hat festival again?

Vila: I'm sorry, Avgust. I think we will have to live without our tin hats and Comrade Blinchik for a long time.

Vila: They are signing on to a reform of our rationing.

Vila: To transform our factories, we need to cut down the budget for the canteen.

Avgust: Oh, thank you for your sacrifice, Comrade Blinchik.

Avgust: You deserve a medal and some chocolate!

Pasono: Look, the bulldozers are tearing down those houses!

Vila: Yes. We all agreed to exchange some of our living space.

Vila: For more land to grow food.

The children crowd the window, silent but beaming with pride, as if paying tribute.

Windsong follows Vila's narrative to its conclusion.

Windsong: The price is much higher than it first seemed. Is it worth it?

Vila: Of course.

Vila: You cannot find what we have here in Zeno's barracks, or in a relief camp. You can't find it anywhere in the world.

Vila: Think about the old comrades and the babies. They are the past and the future of Rayashki. How could we leave them behind or subject them to Zeno's whims?

Mechanical sounds from outside carry across the snow from afar, as if the land itself is calling.

Vila: No one shall ever be abandoned in Rayashki.

Windsong: I think people out there would be envious if they saw what you are doing here.

She doesn't press further.

Vila: We really aren't doing anything so special. We're only doing our job, our duty to one another.

Her scales and spines have risen, though whether it's a sign of pride or fear, she can't say.

Windsong: There are lots of conflicts out there, conflicts like the one between humans and Rusalki.

Windsong: Like the ones that mocked the study of ley lines and dissolved our school. They did so simply because it might take from their funds or steal their glory.

Windsong: Everyone forever building walls, just to keep separated from each other—Hoarding whatever they could get their hands on.

Windsong: Then they blame the aftermath—the harm they do to others on "cruel realities."

Windsong: Heh, "cruel reality." It seems to be everyone's mortal enemy, the cause of all suffering, war, greed—the perfect excuse to never care.

Her voice trails into a mutter.

Vila: But things are different in Rayashki.

Vila: They took me in unconditionally when I came here. And they stayed friendly for a week, a month, a year, and even now.

Vila: So naturally, it became my dream, too.

Vila: Everyone here shares a beautiful dream, a dream that we can work and enjoy life together.

Vila: That someday there will be no more conflicts between people or worries about tomorrow. That everyone will be able to work to achieve their passions whatever field they wish to pursue. A utopia.

Vila: It's not just a way of life for now, but the future we're always trying to reach.

Windsong: ...

Vila: I've spread the study of ley lines in Rayashki, along with its potential.

A simple invitation catches Windsong's eye, with dense, messy signatures filling every possible space.

Vila: They showed great interest. The study tells us about the secrets that could lie beneath the earth, after all.

Vila: "Perhaps it will bring hope to Rayashki."

Windsong: But, I'm not one of you.

Vila: You taught the children something new, and you helped us explore our town's potential, didn't you?

Vila: Everyone here is more than happy to help you. You know, Comrade Knut has been boasting about the assistance he was able to provide for your studies.

Vila: And many others are envious. They want to help you, too.

Vila: More importantly, you already have a group of curious students here willing to study your theory.

Windsong: ...

Vila: Now, allow me to ask you again, Comrade Windsong.

Vila: Would you hold a lecture on ley lines for all the citizens of Rayashki?

Windsong: Even though my research doesn't have any endorsements or achievements?

Vila: Of course. Perhaps we can be the first to endorse it, after your lecture.

Windsong: You're being far too obvious in your recruitment tactics.

Vila smiles, ignoring her feigned protest.

Vila: The world is not a beautiful place. Poverty, privilege, egoism, exclusivism, so many problems.

Vila: But that doesn't mean it can't get better in the future.

Vila: Perhaps, the experiment we're doing in Rayashki now will become the symbol of a better future, a new world where all races and ideas can coexist.

Vila: Well, of course, it may fail and end up a ruin.

Vila: But at least we've tried.

Windsong: ...

She watches Vila standing proudly, as if gazing at a great ship bound for distant shores.

Venturing all, never shrinking back.

Vila: We love our home, and we're ready to devote our lives to it.

Windsong: I can't shake the feeling you're inviting me aboard a leaky boat that could sink any moment.

Vila: Maybe, Comrade Windsong. But should we sink, remember your friend is a Rusalka, and we do well underwater.

Windsong blinks, half-wondering if her new friend has gone mad.

And finding it madder still that she is reaching out to solemnly accept the invitation.

Windsong: What an honor.

8#1

So Long, Zeno!

FR-13

People's Square, Rayashki

The crowd has gathered together again.

Windsong: I ...

It is a familiar place—one she's visited in dreams before.

This time, though, her watchers seem more curious than doubtful.

Their eager eyes follow her every move.

Windsong: Today, I am going to introduce the study of ley lines.

Windsong: And the progress of my research on Rayashki.

Windsong takes a deep breath, pulling out a few pages of research notes.

The pages are passed from hand to hand, stirring excitement.

Windsong: Thanks to your help, I have finished a draft of the town's ley energy map.

Windsong: And I have confirmed the presence of many precious resources.

Knut: Through these colorful lines?

Windsong: These lines and spots show us the state of local ley energy. Each color represents a different concentration of creatures or minerals.

Windsong: Simply put, this area covered in frozen earth and frost contains many rich resource veins.

Windsong: These gray marks symbolize them. They are located in most of the corners of the map, all of them outside of town.

Resident I: Oh! Maybe that's why Grandpa said we couldn't grow anything here in the beginning.

Resident I: They eventually solved that problem by importing rich black topsoil for our fields.

Windsong: As for the runium you've mined to make a living, look at the dark gray marks.

Windsong: According to the map, they are becoming increasingly scattered and faint, so it can be hard to see them.

Knut: ...

Windsong: Besides resources, we can also find concentrations of different creatures using the map.

Windsong: The navy blue marks represent the Qiqirn, while the aqua green ones represent the mutant Qiqirn from the wharf. They feed on plants, and you can find their traces in many corners of the town.

Windsong: The red brown marks are the Kikituks, an aggressive species. They're vicious by nature and prey on just about anything arcane they can find, even other creatures.

Knut: I feel as though my head is going to explode from all this new information. Can you explain a little simpler for this old workhorse, Comrade Windsong?

Windsong: Of course.

She proudly produces a small handful of fluff.

Windsong: This sample comes from a Kikituk in the mine. I took it with Mr. Evgeni's help.

Evgeni: ...

Knut: Seems like just a normal piece of fluff, no matter how I look at it.

Windsong: Yes, and in most people's eyes, it's nothing more than that.

Windsong: But in a ley hunter's eyes, it reveals a great deal of information.

Windsong: Ah. The navy blue marks and the red brown ones seem to mix together. And there are also dark gray ones popping out among them.

Windsong: So it looks like our Mr. Kikituk ate well. Perhaps he had a Qiqirn soup with runium-flavored kefir.

Knut: Hahaha, looks like these critters have realized our dream long before we could.

Resident II: But what about those black marks?

Resident II: If my memory serves me right, the map you just showed us had those black marks, too.

Windsong: Yes, but they don't match any creature or resource we know.

Windsong: I believe it represents a new kind of resource.

The Other Resident: Oh! Well, where is it then?!

The mood has intensified, residents clamoring around to see.

Windsong: We can only find the answer in this area here.

Knut: You mean in the depths of the mine?

Windsong gives a slow affirmative nod.

Windsong: The ley energy is emanating from there. Afterwards, it flows throughout the "food chain," passing through all kinds of creatures and materials before eventually returning to its source.

Windsong: Then our new resource is probably somewhere there.

Knut: So we need to find it! Then we won't have to put up with Zeno anymore!

The audience sparks up. Rippling murmurs turn into a burst of questions and excitement.

Knut: But, do you have any other proof?

He lays out his hands, as if expecting Windsong to put something there.

Windsong: Of course. Remember the critter you found in the mine, Mr. Knut?

Knut: Yes, you said it was called, em, a Hoi-Hoitoo.

Windsong: Hoituk, a subspecies of Kikituk. They live underground and feed on minerals.

Knut: That was around the time we had begun to run out of runium.

Windsong: Is that so? But they were still there, perhaps even more active than usual. That could only mean they were attracted by some other mineral or energy source, right?

Windsong: And even though I didn't find any further Hoituks during my research, I did find the Olga mutants, one of their close relatives.

Windsong: Since they are social creatures, my discovery must prove the presence of some of these Hoituks, even if we cannot find them yet!

The surrounding cheers swell again, prompting Evgeni to clear his throat.

Evgeni: But in the end, this is all just conjecture. Are we really going to waste all our time and money on your assumptions?

Evgeni: Or can you prove it's something more than conjecture?

Windsong: I would call it a preliminary conclusion.

Evgeni: But could it be endorsed by any authorities or proven theories?

Windsong: So far, no.

Evgeni: So then, it is little more than a fairy tale. Am I right?

Windsong: I admit it's a gamble.

Evgeni's now-infamous brow furrows once more.

Evgeni: It's never easy to dig, you know.

Evgeni: And Zeno has already withdrawn all their own equipment. All we have left in Rayashki are some outdated machines.

Evgeni: Besides, Ms. Windsong mentioned the critters. Maybe their presence there is some kind of proof, but they are themselves a danger.

Evgeni: It is obvious that there will be many more critters there than near the town.

Evgeni: And you would have us waste time—perhaps even sacrifice our comrades—to pursue what could just be a fairy tale?

Windsong: ...

He advances closer, step by step.

Windsong's mouth opens silently. The look on his face far too familiar.

The moment before the collapse of ley line academia.

Yes, that is the look.

The suffocating weight of questions and regrets.

Examiner I: There is no doubt, the cost is simply too high.

Examiner I: Who would be foolish enough to dig some holes in the wild just to see if there are critter bones in there?

Harsh sounds of laughter come from everywhere and nowhere all at once.

Examiner I: The answer is very clear. We don't need a new kind of geography mixed with arcanum. Let's save everybody some trouble.

Examiner I: Conclusion: the application for Project: Ley Line should be rejected.

Examiner II: Agreed.

Windsong: I ...

Examiner II: Heh, even cranks can apply for research funds nowadays.

She staggers back.

Bumping into something solid.

A strange yet familiarly cool sensation lands on her shoulder.

Vila stands behind her.

Vila: Keep moving, Comrade Windsong. Keep moving.

Vila: The people of Rayashki don't back down in the face of their problems.

Windsong: ...

Vila: Whatever it is, we can fix it together, right?

Windsong: ...

Vila: I approve of Comrade Windsong's proposal.

Residents: Me too!

Her surging ship launches forward, plowing through stubbornness and doubt.

Never looking back.

Windsong: That's right.

Windsong: This is not a gamble or a fairy tale.

Her hands tremble as she opens her backpack.

Windsong: Here's a ley line simulator.

Windsong: It can simulate the creatures on the ley energy map, so we can do further analysis.

Vila: Is it able to simulate the critters, too?

Windsong: Certainly. Simulating critters is lesson one in the ley line textbook.

Windsong: We can use the simulation to carry out targeted training against the critters.

Vila: Looks like the study of ley lines is more organized than I thought.

Vila: Congratulations, Comrade Windsong. You will have the manpower you need.

Windsong turns as more and more fists are raised into the air.

Resident I: Turn it on, comrade!

Resident II: We can't wait!

A deep breath, a glance to confirm that all is ready, then ...

click

"Kikituk": *roars*

Evgeni: ...!

Evgeni instinctively positions himself in front of everyone.

Knut: Hahahaha, it's like digging the mine all over again!

The Other Resident: That was the biggest achievement of my life!

Knut: Let's do this, comrades!

Knut: Digging like this is no easy work!

They roll up their sleeves, pressing forward confidently.

Knut: Phew! That was one powerful blow. Hahahahaha!

The square is now pocked by groups of disheveled workers, resting after their rigorous exertion.

Windsong's back is soaked, and her simulator creaks with stress.

Vila: I think we can draw our conclusions now.

creak

The old bench groans beneath her boots as she nimbly propels herself onto its narrow back.

Vila: Everyone! We have to admit this is going to be a risky operation, but it's also our last chance.

Vila: To protect our land and our people!

Vila: We must explore the mine!

Vila: There will be danger; yes, some of us may get hurt, but we may also find this new resource and save our Rayashki.

Vila: For you, for me, for everyone!

There is no cheer that rises to meet her. The only thing audible now is the distant sea breeze buffeting the shore.

Vila: We can already expect that critters have occupied the mine. We'll just have to work together to drive them away!

Vila: We dug this mine with our old machines once, and we'll do it again!

Vila: This is how we've made it so far.

The crowd rises, pulling in together. Windsong looks up and outward.

Knut: However old they are now, they will always be our children, right?

Knut: Yuri, you are good at assembling, huh? Nikita, you're going to be busy with the engines. Valeriya, we need you for the screws!

Residents: ...

More and more stars light up.

They outshine the twinkling snow.

8#1

The Future We Choose · 1/2

FR-14

Days Later

Children's Square, Rayashki

Nina: Ms. Vila, they've been doing strange things.

Pyotr: Father took out a lot of old books, and he spends most of his time looking over his blueprints now. He said, "They will be the key to saving the town."

Pyotr: Shame I can't read those books or help with anything.

Nina: My dad was acting strange, too. He started fiddling with the bottles from under his bed again.

Nina: But Mom didn't scold him this time. She even took out some of her treasures from the cabinet.

Nina: Reindeer horn, Noisy Birch sap, Golden-Teeth Seal whiskers.

Nina: Dad said his potions would keep everyone energetic for a whole day.

Pyotr: Even Mr. Miser took out his wand from the safe box!

The children cluster around Vila, pleading for answers.

Vila: Heh heh.

Vila is about to speak when hurried laboring footsteps interrupt her.

Patrik: Move, kids.

Patrik: Good luck, Comrade Vila.

Regrettably, his march cannot proceed.

As he's now become the children's newest focus.

Nina: Mr. Patrik.

Nina: Are you doing strange things, too?

The book bag on his shoulder cannot elude the children's scrutiny.

It is not a cookbook he carries, but something far weightier.

Nina: How to Use and Maintain Model Э-050, Operation Manual of Model СК-1562 ...

Nina: These dusty books ... They look older than me!

Patrik: Hahaha, these "old friends" are our textbooks.

Pasono: Do adults take exams, too?

Patrik: We're doing something far more important than exams, kids.

Patrik: We haven't used these old fellas since Zeno brought the new ones. Most of our comrades don't know how to operate them.

Patrik: Now is the time to put them back into use. Comrade Knut has been teaching us how to use these "outdated" technologies.

Vila: That's right. All the adults have been divided into many groups.

Vila: Knut is leader of the engineering group, and Pasono's uncle is in the investigation group, while Nina's father has joined the potion group.

Vila: All of them take part in the critter combat training at dusk every day, and we share our combat experience with each other.

Vila: And everyone is working hard to explore the mine.

The children burst into questions, seeking the current whereabouts and activity of every single adult they can think of.

Patrik: Haha! We will be able to live on our own without Zeno!

Pyotr: Ms. Vila, I want the town to be proud of me, too!

Nina: Is there anything that we can do?

Pasono: I have lots of metal toy trains. Can we make components out of them?

Pasono: They can spin and whistle like a mine cart!

Vila: That's a great idea. I'm sure it will inspire everyone.

Pyotr: No! Let them use mine first!

Hands shoot up among the children, each a ready volunteer.

Patrik: Calm down, children. I know you want to do your bit.

Patrik: But our future needs you.

Patrik: Now, your job is to study hard, so Rayashki can rely on you in the future.

Patrik: Understand?

Nina: Oh. What about Avgust? We can't find him.

Nina: He'll be so sad if he doesn't get to have a job too.

Vila: *chuckles*

Vila: Don't worry, Nina. He's helping the town in his own way.

Abandoned Mine, Rayashki

Kikituk: *roars*

Avgust: Ears!

A gunshot sounds, and a Kikituk swiftly scurries away.

Kikituk: *roars*

Avgust: Whiskers!

The boy is a conductor of a symphony of arms.

Gunfire and the noise of battle follow in the wake of the little sunflower's hands.

Resident I: It's only been a few months. Can't believe the monsters have already occupied the whole place.

Resident II: Well, not a problem as long as we got our mischievous little comrade. He always knows exactly where they will come out.

Resident I: Things wouldn't have gone nearly as smoothly without him.

Resident II: I would never have believed he could do this if Comrade Windsong hadn't endorsed him.

Resident I: "Never underestimate any of our comrades, big or small." Do I need to repeat that again?

Of course, Avgust is securely guarded, despite his dangerous mission.

Windsong: Well done, Avgust. You protected everyone.

Avgust: Protected?

Avgust: But I was just teaching our monster friends how to dance right. They are slow learners.

Windsong: Yes, that's what we want you to do.

She struggles to match her words to her little friend's own imaginative interpretations.

Windsong: A performance with the Kikituks.

Windsong: Your job is to tell which critter, emm, I mean, which friend, is dancing wrong.

Windsong: That's your talent, isn't it? Just like you showed us before!

Avgust: Oh!

Avgust: But, what if they dance right?

Windsong: Mmm.

Avgust: Then, they deserve some Alenka chocolate, don't they?

Indeed, for all those scattered, many more come slinking in behind them.

They shadow every move, intent on repelling their intruders.

Avgust: Comrade Sergiyan, our new friend is right beside your boots. I think he is hoping to kiss them. Will you dance with him?

The Other Resident: What?

Windsong: Watch out!

Kikituk: *roars*

Walk faster

小径

We should take these components to the appropriate comrade. With my years of experience in mining, I can assure you that they are still usable and will be put to good use.

Maybe they contain traces of runium, explaining their pristine appearance. In these times of steel shortages, every little contribution counts ...

I imagine Comrade Vila is with the children right now, making sure they don't miss their lessons.

Could it be that the miners have returned to the abandoned mine? Maybe we should take the shorter route to the hotel and let Comrade Evgeni investigate.

Alright, let's do that.

...

Shh, see those people walking in front of the hotel? Are they from Zeno? Let's not talk about them behind their backs.

Yeah, I see them. Isn't Comrade Evgeni negotiating with Zeno? They must be looking for him.

They left. It looks like Comrade Evgeni isn't there. We'll have to come back later.

Tomorrow or the day after, perhaps.

...

Honestly, this is not the way I want to leave this town.

Ugh, I still have the scars from shoveling snow on my legs, and we just fixed the windows at home. Who wants to leave just like that?

But what Comrade Evgeni said was reasonable, and he is always truthful ...

You're afraid he'll hear you! We may be close to the meeting room, but—

I'm not afraid, or I wouldn't have made the decision to come here. We weren't afraid in the pioneer days either. What Comrade Vila says is exactly what everyone said back then.

The town has been built, and we have been living here for a while now. Our days are not as hectic as they used to be, but it is invigorating to see the resurgence of the pioneer spirit after such a long time!

Hey, alright! That's the attitude we need! If we walk a little faster, we can still make it back to work on time!

Walk faster

The Future We Choose · 2/2

FR-14

zap

The Other Resident: Ah!

Evgeni: Back off!

Evgeni surges forward, white light piercing the last Kikituk's nostrils.

Kikituk: ...!

Evgeni pushes the carcass aside, allowing blood to drip onto the snow.

He fixes intently on Windsong.

Evgeni: There are many more critters than we can deal with here.

Evgeni: Many of us are injured. We must retreat.

Faint moans rise from a stretcher, bandages and bloodstains accumulating in a small mound on the snow.

Knut: We made the decision to come here together, Comrade Evgeni.

Knut: We are so close to the depths. We must not give up now!

The Other Resident: Hiss, ah! I know everyone's wounded, but look how far we've gone. It's been worth it, don't you think?

Windsong: This is all my fault. I'm sorry.

Knut: Don't be, Comrade Windsong. You've given us a workable plan and helped us recognize our little comrade's potential, no?

He ruffles Avgust's head.

Evgeni: He's only a child.

Knut: He's one of us, Comrade Evgeni. I will keep him safe.

Knut: We aren't just digging a mine now.

Knut: If we manage to find this resource, no one will have to leave, and we can continue to live together, right?

Evgeni: Hmph!

Scattered applause burst up like firecrackers, until it becomes a thundering display.

Rifles, refurbished and polished, rise in harmony with pickaxes and tools.

Knut: These wounds are nothing compared to the glory of our future.

Evgeni: Again, I think this is a foolish idea.

He says nothing else, then turns to leave without looking back.

Windsong: ...!

8#1

O, Grass-Roots

FR-15

Evgeni: It's me.

Windsong: Oh, you!

Evgeni: I want to talk.

Hotel, Rayashki

Windsong: I was just about to look for you, Comrade Evgeni. I've found more details!

Windsong: Here.

Windsong turns away and begins to search through the mountainous piles of documents.

Windsong: Trust me, they will ease your mind, more or less.

A cold wind rushes between them through the open window.

Evgeni: Let's skip to the point.

Evgeni: I want you to stop your research.

Windsong: What?

Evgeni: Our exploration has only just started, yet many of our people have already been hurt.

Evgeni: Can you promise there won't be further injuries, or worse, before we've found this fairy-tale treasure?

Evgeni: Your so-called new resource is still unconfirmed, yet the price we've paid looking for it is already mounting. We had other options, safer options for all of us.

The snow has turned to wet rain; it splashes up from the windowsill and on to her as they speak.

Windsong: We just need to be better prepared. We will arm ourselves with more knowledge for next time.

Evgeni: I know what you're after here: the study of ley lines, right?

Evgeni: The people here may be enthusiastic, but they are only laymen. I've spoken with someone who can help you far more.

The unhurried steps of expensive boots mark an unfortunately familiar guest.

Bertolt: It is good to see you, Ms. Windsong.

Bertolt: Our proud scholar of a budding, if still informal, school.

His expression is genuine and surprised, as though this is the first time they've ever met.

Windsong: And you, the Big Shot from Zeno. Should I feel flattered you stopped by?

He feigns obliviousness to Windsong's teasing.

Bertolt: I read your files, as Mr. Evgeni suggested.

Bertolt: You know already that Zeno has investigated many arcane cases and been deployed to many places related to arcanum, but we have never met anyone quite as obsessive in their study as you are.

Windsong: What now? Have the big shots decided they are going to trust my studies?

Bertolt smiles. He always smiles, brimming with all the joy of a crocodile.

Bertolt: Well, while I might admire your perseverance myself, no, they're not convinced.

Bertolt: We just wonder what you and your school have gained from this long journey?

He looks past her, assessing the mounds of scattered papers.

Windsong: Enough with the crap.

Bertolt: As you wish. First, I believe you owe Comrade Evgeni some thanks.

Windsong: Huh?

A fresh letter of recommendation is handed to Windsong.

Bertolt: The less than satisfactory results from your study may not have earned this letter from Zeno, but Comrade Evgeni insisted on us offering it to you.

Bertolt: Once you have our recommendation, you will be able to communicate with all the renowned scholars in our lab. Your long wait for recognition will be over. A once-in-a-lifetime opportunity.

His tone is calm. His victory is assured.

Evgeni: All I ask is stop this farce.

Windsong: Heh!

Windsong: Well, I am so grateful. I think I might cry.

Windsong: All we have to do is wait for Zeno's grace to be bestowed on us. We should be moved to tears by your mercy, no?

Bertolt: Putting aside your sarcasm, I would suggest you consider the danger of throwing away this opportunity.

Bertolt: You are wasting time, effort, maybe even lives on some foolish wild goose chase. We can offer the people here a much safer and more feasible way forward. Don't you see?

Bertolt raises an eyebrow. He presents his case less as reason than as indisputable truth.

Windsong: And what about Rayashki?

He looks at her pitifully.

Bertolt: All things come to an end. It will disappear quietly, overtaken by the wilds of this land, when the time comes.

Bertolt: At least, it may leave a small place in the historical records.

Bertolt: No offense intended, Mr. Evgeni.

Evgeni: We cannot solve the problems we're having without Zeno's help.

Windsong: All of these problems will be solved as long as we find this new resource.

Bertolt: Ahem! I'm afraid you're mistaken, Ms. Windsong.

Bertolt: As far as Zeno is concerned, the value of this land is exhausted, fairy-tale resources notwithstanding. Once we've transferred the arcanists away, Rayashki will be abandoned.

The crocodile smile cracks again, growing annoyed at his now long-overdue victory.

Bertolt: We are aware of the danger that staying here poses to these people, and it is our responsibility to save them. Whether they wish to resist us or not. That's the only reason for our decision, understand?

Windsong: ...!

Windsong sets down the ley energy chart, the culmination of her countless efforts, without saying a word.

Bertolt: Let's be practical.

Bertolt: Zeno has many outstanding young people, a strong academic atmosphere, a better future. You will get your opportunity to revive your school of ley lines, if you pass the exam.

Windsong: ...

Her fingers press onto the paper, tracing a newly embossed seal.

The "carrot" is sweeter and more fragrant than before.

How long now had she imagined this moment?

In dim, stuffy basements, in underpaid editorial offices, under faceless, nameless, scrutinizing gazes.

Bertolt: This will be a better choice for all of you.

Windsong: Haha.

Windsong: Mr. Big Shot, could you use your rusted brain to think of a more noble reason than consumerism and elitism?

Windsong: Do you really think our desire for a better life is the only reason why we refuse to leave?

Windsong: You used ordinary people as a stepping stone to power and privilege, and even now you take our sacrifices for granted.

Bertolt: Reality is cruel: not you, not Rayashki, and not even Zeno can save everyone. You will have to deal with that.

Bertolt: You should take what is to come as an inevitable optimization of our society's development.

Windsong: I know. Life may still get harder even if we find this new resource.

Windsong: So what?

The defiance in her voice reignites her long-lost courage.

Windsong: Your brand of elitism may have invaded every corner of the world, but not this town, not yet.

Bertolt: I see, most scholars like you hold the same naivete.

Windsong: They refuse to leave any of their "comrades" behind, even if the price is their own future.

Evgeni: ...

Windsong: What we would sacrifice ourselves for is not the study of ley lines, or any other personal goals.

Windsong: But our dream to thrive together!

Windsong: To live in a bright future we all can share!

Windsong: As for this ...

She scrunches up his gaudy recommendation.

Windsong: I don't need it.

Bertolt: ...!

Bertolt: *spits* A leopard never changes its spots.

Bertolt leaves his final words hanging in the room, departing without looking back.

The crumpled letter rolls out of the window. It lands in the snow, slowly being covered until there is no trace of it left.

Will things get better?

Windsong, too preoccupied to care, slumps back in her chair, gulping in the crisp air of her new world.

Evgeni: I envy your innocence, Ms. Windsong.

Evgeni: For many years, I believed that our mission was to change the world.

Evgeni: But when I looked up, the gate to the new world was already closed. Little Rayashki just coasted along, and I tried to keep everything the way it was.

Evgeni: But I failed.

Evgeni: Rayashki is doomed. All our efforts, our will, our dreams—nothing can change the creeping reality. We attempted to achieve something meaningful, something that could make history, but ...

Evgeni strains to lift his head, his face obscured in a kind of darkness beyond the reach of light.

Evgeni: The spirit of the times stands against what we are building here, not just Zeno, but the whole world.

Evgeni: That's what reality is like: boring, cruel, disappointing.

The scene falls into a wordless, motionless quiet.

After a long while, Windsong rises.

She has shed all other burdens, and the tantalizing carrot is gone.

Windsong: You are too pessimistic, Comrade Evgeni.

Evgeni: Huh?

Windsong: Zeno has tried to recruit me several times. Do you know what I've learned from all their efforts?

Windsong: They don't want us to explore that mine.

Windsong: They belittled our efforts, offered pity for Rayashki, and then planned out a promising future for us.

Windsong: Yet they didn't give us a hand, even when our people were injured or died.

Windsong: Do you really think they are so eager to stop us just because they don't want any more sacrifices?

Evgeni: ...!

Windsong: Of course not, my friend.

Windsong: A lesson I learned from living in their society ...

Windsong: Never do what your enemies want you to do.

She grasps his shoulder, giving it a shake to pull him up to his senses.

Windsong: Zeno is afraid of us.

Windsong: They are afraid that we may discover a new kindling to relight our fire, that we may burn so brightly that we grow out from their control to create our own future.

Evgeni: You ...

Windsong: But they can't have it their way. Rayashki belongs to us, as does the future!

Faint flickers of that fire seem to be there, somewhere in the man before her.

Evgeni looks up with a complex expression.

Evgeni: I, I will give it some thought, Ms. Wi- ... Comrade Windsong.

8#1

Point of Divergence

小径

Hello, gentlemen.

Hello, comrade of Zeno.

Comrade.

If you're here to see Comrade Evgeni, we can wait a little. Or is there something else important you'd like to discuss?

We talked, and Ms. Windsong was there.

Comrade Evgeni is doing what's best for everyone, we all know that. But I'll tell you, I personally don't want to leave this place. Even if he ...

No, the lady turned down my proposal. And Comrade Evgeni didn't seem too invested in it either.

Isn't Zeno's help good news for all of you?

I can't comprehend the reasoning behind rejecting an abundance of food, a suitable climate, and comfortable housing.

It's not easy to leave something you've built with your own hands, comrade. I doubt you've ever experienced living in a home you built yourself, let alone living in this way!

Chances are you have never even touched freshly mined ore in your life!

That's true, gentlemen. But why do you insist on doing everything yourself?

It seems that our conversation has come to an end. I will stay here until Evgeni arrives and gives an answer, which should be soon.

Point of Divergence

United Hands

小径

An advertisement from the ads page of Wall Street Journal.

> Come to C.C Critter Pawnshop to make extra money!
> TEL: 847-6861XXX
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> Are the cunning, ubiquitous critters annoying you again? Don't take that as bad news, because if you have a critter, you just found yourself enough money to pay your rent! We offer the best, the most precise, and the most honest pricing options you'll ever find! Our shop will buy any critters from the cheapest Carbuncles to the expensive yet delicious Rubberados that keep diners bouncing about! C.C swears on its name that every critter we buy will be treated like a family in compliance with internationally recognized standards of humane treatment!

The Taste of Yesterday

小径

Identical long tables, matching chairs, and potatoes, potatoes, and more potatoes.

In the past, we had access to tin cans and even jam and flour. It was a challenge to transport supplies, but fortunately the weather was cold enough that nothing spoiled during the trip. Time was not an issue in those days, we had an abundance of it.

The little ones used to come and ask for Alenka. While we couldn't indulge their every whim, a treat now and then was fine. Being too strict does no one any good.

Had I known the true value of Alenka, I would have been more careful about giving them away. Maybe I could have kept a few. Oh well, too late to regret now.

At first, we gathered around a single table to portion out the canned food, meticulously sopping up every last drop of broth. But now, there are more tables, but a lot less variety in our meals. And it's not like we can go hunting for critters to supplement our meals.

Why can't people live off ore like they do?

I have an urge to give a detailed account of my past and present experiences because Rayashki is exceptional; it is the most remarkable town I've encountered, although my travels have been limited.

But I'm worried that it will one day disappear.

That's for sure. If Comrade Evgeni agrees to Zeno's proposal, this place will soon be a land of snow again. The factories, the machines, everything will be covered with snow, just as it was when we first arrived ...

I have to remember to write down all the details in case the kids ask me. I want to be able to tell them about everything that disappeared. Of course, it's not going to be written down in any textbooks ...

There are countless unsung heroes in Rayashki, a place filled with ordinary people just trying to make ends meet. That's the reality of our lives here.

The Taste of Yesterday

Marching March · 1/2

FR-16

New Mine, Rayashki

The steel behemoths rumble.

They have plowed through snow, mud, and soil to reach their target.

Windsong: ...

Windsong: I haven't done any field investigation of ley energy since our school fell apart.

Windsong puts away her tools, hands trembling slightly.

Knut: Don't worry, Comrade Windsong. Look, these stones are still the same stones we've always known.

He catches the worry in Windsong's expression.

Knut: And don't be afraid to fail. My father told me that failure is just success in progress, hahaha!

Knut: Even if we cannot find this new resource or save our Rayashki ...

Knut: We've come back here together and worked for our common goal. We have nothing to complain about.

Windsong: Alright.

Knut: Whatever the result, we thank you for your efforts.

Knut: Now leave the rest to us!

He turns his head and shouts toward the drilling machine.

Knut: Comrade Yuri, check the connection status.

Knut: Don't forget to check the drill, Comrade Elena.

Worker I: Relax. It's much easier than opening a can with only your fingers.

Workers: Hahahahaha!

The excited queue flows like a steady river.

People crowd together, shovels, hoes, and picks ringing out in unison.

Magnificent drilling machines emerge up from the snow.

They roar as their drills pierce the earth.

The stubborn frozen soil does nothing to hinder their progress.

Their resonance is a sound that echoes in Windsong's ears, the sound of impassioned unity of purpose and vision.

This place is like the square, like their public canteen, like their factory.

Like every corner of Rayashki.

Clearly, it is a scene worth capturing.

Avgust: Knut had grown a slender arm. One that reached places no one could and picked up stones there.

Avgust: They are not like the soft, transparent stones from the sky; these are hard as chocolate!

Avgust: I think they are good stuff, too. Vila said we could make them into cans and houses to help the town!

Avgust: But maybe we will irritate the owner of the stones?

The busy adults pay no heed to the child's mutterings.

They gather around the newly collected core samples.

Worker I: Am I right that this sample is from 100 meters underground?

Worker II: Yes. Usually, we don't need to reach that deep to find runium ore.

Knut: Relax, comrades. At least, it proves there is something new under Rayashki.

Worker II: Hmm, I have been a miner for forty years, and one thing I know for sure is this: this is not bedrock.

Windsong: It's a Kikituk's hair.

Windsong carefully scrapes the colorful powder from the rocks and places it into a test tube.

Windsong: The black marks are the new resource we're looking for, the red brown ones are the Kikituks, and the bright yellow ones are their mineral-eating relatives, the Hoituks.

Windsong: Hmm. The machine will show us the stability of the ley energy in a minute.

Windsong: We are at the source of the ley energy now, so the lines should have been pure.

Knut: If my eyes serve me right, I think I see bad news.

Windsong: You're right. This source is like an estuary polluted beyond recovery.

Windsong: It is carrying too many traces, both from creatures and non-creatures. Besides, the "black" ore down there seems to have attracted a large number of critters, which has only worsened the pollution.

Windsong: A senior of mine said in his notes that in this case, it will take a push for the core to activate its self-purification system.

Knut: Huh?

Windsong: Shoot, we got a big one!

Avgust: Waves! It's seawater!

Avgust: We should have prepared swimming floats.

Avgust: Yes, but the waves won't reach us if we ride the sled!

There is a slight hum from the vibration.

Windsong: "If the ley energy materializes, put in a 7.62cm sea serpent bone, 3 drops of common vervain sap, and 20mg of snail sawfish embryo ..."

The Emergency Ley Energy Handling Guidelines (Trial) booklet in her hand is thrown to the ground and stamped aggressively.

Windsong: Crazy! Whoa!

A colored slime continues to ooze out.

No longer a mere note in her reference materials, but an observable substance.

The clever dreamer continues his observation.

Avgust: It has a beautiful stone on its neck, too!

Avgust: Did your father also fall asleep in the mine?

Windsong: D**n! Is that the raw runium ore that Zeno has been looking for? The energy is so pure. No wonder it materialized into such a huge body.

Drawn in by the spectacle, more creatures emerge from nearby mine shafts.

Kikituk: *roars*

Enticed by the potential for a feast.

Vila: Comrades, defense formation.

Vila: Miners, stay behind us and evacuate!

Knut: Comrades! Stand with me if you've got a weapon! No matter if it's a rifle, a staff, or a shovel. Grip them tight. This is our Rayashki's future we're fighting for!

Knut: We've been waiting for this, haven't we?

The Other Resident: That's right.

More "weapons" are raised, clanging together as they begin their battle march.

Vila: Dear comrades.

Vila: This is the critical moment for our town.

Vila: No good weapons, no external support, but we have our friends, our family ...

Vila: And each other, who will never leave anyone behind!

Windsong: Yes!

Windsong: There's nothing to be afraid of.

Windsong: We can always figure it out, so long as ...

Vila: So long as we still have hope.

Voices ring out one after another as they reach the end of their march.

A Heartfelt Legacy

小径

You're here, Comrade Vila.

Comrade Windsong and Comrade Raisa helped me take the children home; it took some time.

What did you find?

Comrade Evgeni once mentioned that he kept some things in the cabinet in the meeting room.

He said to take them out when the time was right.

...

Here. This is all of it.

A Heartfelt Legacy

Dodgy Excavators

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Needles and Loaves

小径

Comrade Vila frequents this place, always looking great in her poneva dress.

I taught her how to sew, and other comrades would bring piles of torn coats and socks for us to mend. This is something I have always done.

No matter how catchy our slogans are, we still need clothes to wear and bread to eat, right? The rest is not within my realm of concern.

Thankfully, Comrade Vila has been diligently caring for the children. My main worry was that once the teachers were gone, there would be no one to check on them and ensure they were looked after.

Leaving children to run amok on the streets will not lead to their healthy development.

I'm very grateful that she's here.

...

This place has become a second home to me. Despite the challenges and endless tasks, I feel content knowing that our efforts benefit our fellow comrades.

This experience is priceless to me. Anyone who has ever sat at a long table, sharing butter and conversation with people from different countries and working together to form friendships would understand the value of this way of life.

It has a powerful effect, my friend. It reminds me of dark bread - rough, but filling.

Whether it is Comrade Vila or ... Comrade Evgeni, I trust in their abilities. This town will not simply disappear.

Rayashki will always be here, steadfast and unwavering.

Needles and Loaves

Town Square Meet-Up

小径

Side by Side

Miners, covered in a layer of dust and wielding their picks, hurry over as others join them after washing off their bandages. In the square, some take shelter under the statue and read books, while children are led by loving hands through rows of coats and boots. A strong sense of camaraderie unites everyone in the square; they are all part of the same tight-knit community.

The conversations begin and spread like a hurricane, sweeping from one end of the square to the other as everyone tries to engage with those around them. But then another voice joins in. The town's teacher has arrived, embodying the ideals we hold dear. She is like a character from a legend who has come to our town from a faraway place. Because of our strong will, even legends can become reality here. If the teacher had not said, "See you tomorrow!" this would have gone on all night.

As a community, we each have a voice in shaping the future of our town. It's inspiring to see so many people come together to make a difference. There is a sense of pride that radiates from within, uniting us all towards a common goal.

Oh, how powerful it is when we come together as one!

Marching March · 2/2

FR-16

The nosey critters have all disappeared, and the strange entity has slumped down.

The gathered warriors are exhausted, but alive.

Vila: Did we make it?

Windsong: After we drove the critters away, the self-purification system began to run slower.

Knut: Haha! Time to go all out. Let's go, comrades!

Worker I: For a brighter future!

The crowd redoubles their strength as they follow Knut forward.

Ley Energy?: ...!

Deafening sounds reverberate all around them.

A brilliant red splashes across the snowfield.

Worker II: Oh!

Vila: Comrade Yuri! Get a few more comrades here. We need to move him to the back!

Many comrades are wounded, blood soaking their arms, but their hearts have not faltered.

Never retreat, never surrender.

Windsong: Its energy has not run out yet. What on earth ...

Ley Energy?: *roars*

Windsong: That's the ore! D**n it! Don't tell me it's still powering this thing!

Worker I: I see. So we just break that stone, and it's over, right?

Windsong: Yes, theoretically.

Windsong's voice wavers as she catches her breath.

Guard I: Leave it to me. I am the marksman here! Just need to get a little closer, a little closer.

Guard II: Comrade Adrian, Comrade Daniel, and I will go with you. There may be something we can do!

Guards: Okay!

Vila: Comrades, watch out!

They charge ahead, their spirits unwavering.

Vila: No!

Knut: Fall back, fall back!

Bullets fly through the air, their sound like a relentless pounding hail.

Ley Energy?: ...

Knut: S**t! Our attacks cannot break that stone at all.

Vila: Comrade Windsong, wh-what is going on?

The red splashes around them, so vivid against the white snow, halt her words.

Windsong: ...

Windsong: The cycle of ley energy is long. It may take months, years, or even longer than that to return to its source.

Windsong: As long as that ore remains on its neck, the ley energy will continue with the purification until it wipes out everything around.

Windsong's voice is low, despite the din of battle.

Knut: So all we can do is wait?

Windsong: For our own safety, we'd better stay out of this area until it completely returns to the source.

Windsong: I should've seen this coming. I'm so sorry.

Surrounded by fallen comrades and dark red streaks, Windsong attempts to conceal the fear in her voice.

The wind rises, sharp and howling.

Knut: Comrade Patrik, Comrade Nikita, you're not done yet, right? Anyone else?

Knut: We still got the digger, the crane, and our own strength! Let's try harder! It's nothing more than a stupid stone! We can do this!

Knut: It's our last chance!

Rough hands stubbornly rise once more, defying the cold wind and danger.

Trickles of blood seep down their arms from cuts and wounds.

Warm words cover them like a bandage, offering some solace to their pain.

Vila: Stop this senseless sacrifice, Comrade Knut. It's pointless to keep going.

Knut: But, to save Rayashki is also your dream, no?!

Knut: Our little one from afar swore she would unite all of us, no matter who we are or where we're from.

Knut: We must keep all that in our minds. How can we give up now?

The massive creature stands unmoving, like an unyielding mountain.

Vila: ...

Vila: I'm so happy I came here and made friends with all of you, comrades. You each have a kind heart and a strong will.

Vila: Before I met you, my dream was only a joke to the other Rusalki, but you've shown me it isn't unreachable. Now it feels so real and heartwarming.

Vila: Sometimes, I almost forget that you see the fins and scales on my body.

Vila: That's why I don't want you to sacrifice yourselves for nothing. I don't want to lose you.

Her smile is a ray of light breaking through the clouds.

Vila: What we want is to stay together. That's why we are fighting to save Rayashki, right?

Knut: F**k this world!

Avgust: *sobs* The swans have lost their feathers.

Avgust: Are we still able to reach the sky?

Snow begins to fall again, as if casting a veil over the dead—over Rayashki.

The roar of the wind grows, but there is something else groaning with it. Clouds are pushed aside, and a distorted voice calls out from above.

Evgeni: I must thank you, Comrade Windsong. You've rekindled something in me, in us—a new hope, just as you promised.

Evgeni: I will tell you that I read some papers on your ley lines after that night. It holds some great ideas, I admit. You and Rayashki deserve a better future.

Windsong: ...!

Avgust: Wow, sea swallow, our brave friend!

Evgeni: Comrades, I want you to know I recommended you to Zeno only because I was worried for your future. I did not want you to be stuck in a dying town.

Knut: Comrade Evgeni?

Evgeni: And it gives me pain to see how brave and determined you all have been. I won't let any of you die here.

Vila: Evgeni, what are you doing!

Evgeni: The sad thing is I took a very different path long ago. But what does it matter now?

Evgeni: Rayashki is proud of you. I am proud of you. You will continue to build the new world of your dreams—our dream, no matter where or when.

Evgeni: I will always be there with you.

Evgeni: Seize the opportunity, Vila, Windsong, my comrades!

Windsong: Природа это числа и черты.

The trails of the old machines wore deep into the frozen ground, forming a raised pathway that led up and away from the scene.

The children, finally coming to grips with what they've seen, begin to cry.

Vila: Comrade Evgeni.

Do fish mourn? Can a Rusalka cry?

No one can really answer this question.

Yet around the Rusalka, a ring of salty water seems to rise.

Knut: D**n it! This is not fair!

Knut: Just because he was the only pilot here doesn't mean he could make that decision alone! We should have had a vote!

Worker I: We fixed that fighter together!

Worker I: That a*****e left us behind.

Worker II: But he will always be our comrade, right?

Time appears to stand still, as all present stand unmoving, unspeaking.

Until one, and then many, trembling hands rise triumphantly into the sky.

Windsong: ...

Residents: To Comrade Evgeni, salute!

Avgust: But where is the sea swallow?!

Vila: He flew into the future, child.

Vila: The future we'll all reach one day.

8#1

Snow, and the Others

FR-17

New Mine, Rayashki

The unsupported ley energy returns to the earth.

The soil is smoothed out, a canvas for a new painting.

Knut: Take heart, comrades.

Knut: Everything he did was for Rayashki.

Vila: We shared the same dream, didn't we?

Vila: To do all we can for the good of the people.

She faces toward the silent cliffs.

Worker I: Reporting: drilling rig clear, ready for new exploration.

Knut: ...

He stomps firmly on the ground beneath his feet.

Knut: That's the spirit! We must keep going! Let's get some wiggles!

Knut: Yuri, start the machines!

Worker II: On it!

A loud call resounds, and the huge drill churns once more.

The steel behemoths roar.

Their sound covering up the sorrow and the gloom of the moment.

After some time, the children carefully and cautiously approach the cliff's edge.

Avgust bends down, placing his sunflower on the edge, as tenderly as a mother tucks in their child.

Avgust: Take this. It's my best friend.

Avgust: I think it will be glad to have another best friend.

Pyotr: I will become a great hero like you. It's a promise, a man's promise.

Avgust: Why are your feathers wet, Pyotr?

Pyotr: ...

Avgust: You have water on your face, Ms. Windsong. Can kids still cry after they grow up?

Windsong: ...

Windsong: I should've known ...

Windsong: The abnormal fluctuation of the ley energy, and how much of an attraction it is to the critters ...

Windsong: I should've noticed they were different from my theory.

Her words are met by murmurs, but a familiar hand wraps hers gently.

Vila: At least this experience will be valuable for the study of ley lines, won't it?

Vila: Take it in, and make something of it. I'm sure it will be of more help in the future.

Vila: You're not only doing this for yourself or for me, but for those who sacrificed for all of us.

Windsong: ...

boom

Worker I: We found it! This must be the new resource!

A stream of black rocks rises from the pile, one by one.

In a short time, they are picked up and passed through countless hands.

The air is thick with black dust that covers coats, gloves, boots, and faces.

Knut: COAL!

Knut: It is coal! We did it!

Patrik: This is our coal! Comrades, we will use it to cook our meal tonight!

Resident II: And it will be the best meal I've ever had!

Patrik: Is that so, Comrade Nikita? You got a problem with my food, huh?

Resident I: Hahahaha!

Knut: I made a rough estimate. The reserves here should last hundreds of years!

Windsong: For the first time in history, the theory of ley lines has been verified.

Vila: There is no doubt your work deserves a fair assessment now.

Windsong: Thank you for your help, Ms. Vila.

Vila: We achieved this together, didn't we?

Windsong: Of course.

Cheers travel forward and back over the crowd and out into the boundless tundra.

They echo against the cliffs.

Windsong: The glory goes to every one of us.

Their joy reaches back to the town, carried in by the victorious comrades-in-arms.

Unfortunately, their now-unwelcome guests seem unable to share in the enthusiasm.

Bertolt: I'm very glad to see you again, Ms. Windsong.

Windsong: Hmph! Are you? You don't look glad at all.

Bertolt: Heh. I admit, I underestimated the people here.

Bertolt: Especially you, Ms. Windsong.

Bertolt: The great heroine who found coal deep beneath the town.

Windsong: So, did I manage to ruin Zeno's little plans?

Bertolt: ...

Her sharp tongue breaks the cool of the no longer smiling crocodile.

Bertolt: We have nothing left to do here. Zeno will leave soon.

Bertolt: I know we disagree on many things, our future included. Still, Zeno looks forward to working with you again, hopefully in a more friendly way.

He extends his hand on his own initiative.

Windsong: I hope so, too.

Windsong: You don't wanna be embarrassed by another lowly researcher again, do you?

Bertolt's hand awkwardly hangs in the air, unanswered.

Bertolt: Goodbye, Ms. Windsong.

Windsong: ...

Windsong: Wait! I have one last question!

Bertolt: Please, I'm at your service.

Windsong: Zeno confirmed the existence of Hoituks in Rayashki months ago, but you just took care of them without letting anyone know.

Windsong: You already knew there would be a large reserve of coal here, didn't you?!

Bertolt: ...

He shrugs and leaves without another word.

8#1

Same as Before

小径

I've always believed it! We can dig through the frozen layers and find ways to survive here. Even when the harsh northern winds gnash their teeth, we can overcome any challenge!

Zeno will have its own specific guidelines that I doubt I'll be able to adapt to, but just like this particular component, we are already refined and capable enough!

Yes, we can live on our own without relying on other leaders.

...

Let me be honest, I am not much of a fighter. The only tools I know how to use are a wrench and pliers. But when push comes to shove, I will make do with whatever I can get my hands on. We need weapons to defend ourselves, and we are not afraid to use them.

It is crucial for children to explore the world. I came here at a young age, on a whim with a friend. We had no experience in shaping workpieces or handling raw materials. Now, my skills are highly valued in this community.

We did not come to Rayashki to have fun. They've got it all wrong.

Same as Before

No Man's Land

小径

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Hello, Rayashki

FR-18

People's Square, Rayashki

The people gather again.

This time, though, there are no more disputes, no resentment.

This is a gathering of joy.

Vila: After thorough discussion, the people of Rayashki have made their final decision.

Vila: I stand here to declare the future direction of Rayashki.

Vila: As of today, Rayashki will be no longer affiliated with any organizations, and all factories dedicated to processing of runium ore will be shut down.

Resident I: What are we going to do for our work, then?

Resident II: I don't want to sit around at home living on benefits!

Vila: There will be many things to do, Comrade Valeriya.

Vila: As the elites above us struggle for power, we ordinary people suffer in darkness.

Vila: But now, there will be a new source of power, one built to lift up the people not to take from them. And it will run on Rayashki coal.

Vila: We will start new factories in Rayashki and explore the possibilities of working with other coal producers nearby.

Vila: We will mine with our own hands and feed ourselves.

Knut: Maybe we can even build a dock and sell our products far away.

The people chatter excitedly.

Vila: We will raise a new banner above Rayashki, one welcoming all ordinary people ...

Vila: ... to come to a livable place with abundant power and job opportunities for their future.

Arms and smiles intermingle, then a rising wave of applause.

The wave washes over everyone, including Windsong.

Vila: What about your plan, Comrade Windsong?

Windsong: ...

Windsong: I think I'm going to stay for a while.

Vila: You need to know that for now we must tighten our belts. Everyone's rations must be cut for some time until Rayashki gets back on its feet.

The researcher does not waver, not in the slightest.

Windsong: At least for now, the study of ley lines belongs here, not in the fancy halls and symposiums of human academia.

Windsong: This place still holds many possible research avenues: monitoring the changes in the environment, further detailing the local ley energy map, maybe even studying the mutation of the Kikituks.

Windsong: I must finish them to further develop the study before it is ready for academia again.

Vila: Then it sounds like you may be with us for a long time yet, good.

They exchange smiles.

Vila: And don't forget, you are expected to cut the ribbon at the ceremony.

An enthusiastic hand reaches out to Windsong once again.

Now, the little arctic town is covered in a strange mix of black coal soot and bright yellow flowers, a warm wind blowing over every inch of soil and each wall, old and new.

It flows like blood through snow-white skin and fluffy pores. A scene like a hand-drawn picture.

Windsong: ...

Windsong walks alone through the town, feeling the energy of the earth beneath her.

Townsfolk pass her.

They nod and greet her with hopeful smiles.

Pyotr: Ms. Windsong, I want to apologize for being rude to you during class.

Pyotr: I'll bring you some Friendship cheese next time, to apologize. I promise!

Knut: You will always be our comrade.

Knut: Hats off to you!

In the distance, children cluster around a vibrant field of sunflowers.

Avgust: Ms. Windsong!

Avgust: I think we performed very well at the ceremony!

The boy, bright as any other sunflower, waves to her as he hops joyfully in the snow.

Avgust: Will you come teach us again?

Nina: We want to learn more, too!

Pasono: Same here!

Avgust: ♪~♪♪~

Avgust: Ms. Windsong, the sunflowers we planted are blooming!

Avgust: We protected the town!

Windsong wants to say something, but a sudden creaking draws up her attention.

She looks up to see a construction crane looming over the town.

The new coal refinery, a school, a hockey field, the dormitories ...

In the boundless future ahead for Rayashki, these buildings will be like speckled grains of sand cast over the tundra.

Windsong: We begin the next chapter of Rayashki today.

Windsong: I'm so glad we will build it together.

Windsong: Hello, Rayashki.

8#1

An Instant

小径

I stumbled across some components. Lately, it seems like everyone is looking for them in their spare time. These little things can definitely come in handy.

The little thing was hidden just behind the base of the statue. It seemed that our resilient bear had found a new home here. The old statue had to be moved to make way for it, but its base remained. I suspected it had left some of its components behind.

Comrade Evgeni ... he did not notice the changes in Rayashki, but change is inevitable and ongoing. He was still holding onto memories of when things were tough and rough.

In those days, this square didn't even exist. We painstakingly dug it out with shovels and carried each stone ourselves.

No one expected Rayashki to end up so beautiful. We were never ones for making plans or dreaming big; we simply rolled up our sleeves and got to work.

Now, Rayashki might change once more. What will it become? Everything is changing so fast. We have a pool and a school; it all seems to have been built in the blink of an eye.

As soon as a project is completed, the difficulties and sacrifices made along the way are quickly forgotten. The immense sense of accomplishment makes us believe that all the hard work was worth it.

I don't want to leave. I'm afraid I'll change faster than this town did. Those who come back later feel like strangers themselves.

It's incredible, isn't it? How things can change in what feels like an instant ...

An Instant

The Factory Spirit

小径

Factories, ores, and Rayashki!

To me, Rayashki seems almost like another name for Runium. Perhaps it is because I am the one responsible for sifting the ore.

While most people came here with grand ideals, I simply signed my name on the list without much thought. It wasn't long before I found myself stepping off the train and into this unfamiliar land. Fortunately, aside from the wild Critters roaming about and the stubborn terrain, life here has been relatively simple.

Regardless, it's all laborious work. And I understand that even Critters have to eat and survive. I forgive them.

But back to the here and now. The factory is finally complete, and we have surpassed our wildest expectations. These accomplishments are not gifts from some higher power, but of our own making!

These are true miracles, not bestowed by any divine entity but created by our own hard work and determination. Just take a look around!

There was a time when I felt nothing, just going through the motions of everyday life. But now I finally feel like I am making a difference. It may not be extraordinary, but it's more than most people achieve in their lives.

Yes, I couldn't have done this alone. It's a rare opportunity to find others willing to work alongside you, swinging hammers and building something meaningful together.

I hope to turn our experiences here into a legend, like the stories of Comrade Evgeni. With a little exaggeration, of course. Young people need these legends to inspire them.

So let's raise a glass to the new factory and all that we have accomplished here together!

The Factory Spirit

A Promise

小径

Vibrant Snowy Square

Take another good look at the square. It hasn't changed much—a polar bear stands in the center, outlined by a faint light, while children eagerly reach out to touch its paws. The snow dusts the bear's head, giving it a serene quality that contrasts with the lively setting. Flowers bloom amidst the white snow, covering most of the stones on the ground. The bear appears to be at peace against the mustard yellow background.

This is an important place in Rayashki, as the town kitchen cannot accommodate such a large number of people. It is often used for public discussions and will continue to serve that purpose. Recently, it was decided to allow children to venture outside and explore the world beyond. The road leading there is bathed in sunlight, decorated with red ribbons that sway in the gentle breeze from the trees.

People find familiar images here that evoke nostalgia and memories of past lives, yet those who come here rarely speak of their homeland. This is the true essence of Rayashki—everything they hoped to see in their homeland, but never did. It's like the distant horizon that Rusalka dreams of as she braves the icy waters, or the intricate illustrations created by traveling ley hunters, or even the homes of Foundation visitors who have long since disappeared. It's what previous generations promised the next: a glimpse of their idealized homeland.

The more impossible an ideal seems, the stronger it becomes—unbreakable in its perceived perfection.

Despite this, there is still so much to strive for and achieve in life.

To Descendants

FR-19

The river of time has moved swiftly in the passing months.

Rayashki is bustling with the sounds of a busy and hopeful community.

Crowds of people, lively and spirited, weave to-and-fro.

Swimming Pool, Rayashki

A disheveled figure hurries into the scene.

Windsong: Thank goodness! I was hoping you'd be here!

Windsong: Oh, erm, is this a bad time?

Vila: Heh heh, no, it's alright. Have a seat.

Vila: I'm not a pure Rusalka. As you can see, I must get in touch with water every once in a while to replenish my power from the ocean.

Windsong: Ahem. Hello, Comrade Vila.

Vila: It's been a while, Comrade Windsong.

Vila: They say you're working hard in the mine, and the study of ley lines is getting popular among the workers.

Windsong: They have helped a lot. My research on the environment wouldn't have gone nearly so smoothly without them.

Windsong: It's given a second life to my studies, and it is growing so well. It has even gained some recognition beyond Rayashki.

Windsong: I, I'm truly happy that I came here.

Vila: I never thought the Comrade Windsong would be so bashful over her accomplishments. I thought you were more stubborn and confident than that.

Windsong: ...

Vila: I'm only teasing, comrade. It's a matter of fact that you are not as fearless as you pretend to be, isn't it?

Vila: That's why we must all stick together to make up for each other's weaknesses and make Rayashki proud! Sorry, speeches have become an occupational habit.

Windsong: Fine, you got me. But it's not a big deal. Just as you are not quite the gentle and demure school teacher that you appear to be, are you, comrade?

Windsong: We're even!

Windsong clears her throat and hands the letter to Vila.

Windsong: Actually, I've come to say goodbye.

Windsong: Laplace has invited me to give a lecture for their European branch. They want me to give a lecture on how I combined environmental analysis with the arcanum based on what we've done here in Rayashki.

Vila: Sounds like a very promising new beginning for your studies.

Windsong: How are things going in the town?

Vila: We are getting more visitors now. It seems people are eager to see something different.

Windsong: I'm sure they will.

Vila: We've also begun cooperating with many governments and agencies near us, including the Foundation.

Vila: They hope to carry out some short-term training on the arcanum for the children.

Another letter is passed on.

Windsong: What's this?

Vila: Open it. It's from the Foundation.

Vila: Mr. Name Day invites me to visit the Foundation and discuss further cooperation. The children are also waiting for me there.

Vila: It seems they mentioned you all the time during their training.

Vila: "Did we miss the ley line exam?"

Vila: "The Foundation has all sorts of incredible things."

"Avgust": Like biting coins, noisy coal balls, a glass pen with rainbows inside. So much fun!

"Pasono": I've mastered a lot of incantations!

"Nina": I miss the town and everyone.

"Avgust": Yeah. We miss Comrade Alenka, Comrade Blinchik, and Comrade Piroshki!

"Pyotr": They say we will be able to go home in a few months!

"Pyotr": I must master the most powerful arcane skills by then, so I can use them to protect the town!

"Avgust": We'll transform into sea swallows!

"Avgust": Then we'll be able to fly and fly to far, far away!

Radio Broadcaster I: The Kaslinska University Hospital received a rare case today.

Radio Broadcaster I: The patient's veins irreversibly transformed into electric wires. As of 18:00, all arterial, venous, and capillary tissues throughout the patient's body have undergone necrosis.

Radio Broadcaster I: The director said they would invite more professionals to the consultation to decide on further research directions.

Radio Broadcaster I: Global Variety News has claimed the case may become one of the greatest unsolved mysteries of the era.

Radio Broadcaster I: They started a new column to analyze possible compatibilities between the patient's new wired veins and different appliances.

Radio Broadcaster I: Please stay tuned for more details.

Radio Broadcaster II: The Flying Carpet Travel Agency is starting a tour around Northern Europe ...

Radio Broadcaster II: ... where you will be able to see the breathtaking aurora borealis, pet fluffy Qiqirns, and even enjoy a flying carpet race.

Radio Broadcaster II: The destination of our tour is Rayashki.

Radio Broadcaster II: A mysterious town, the warmest place in the Arctic Circle, sitting atop many rich veins of coal.

Radio Broadcaster II: When you get there, we suggest that you abide by the town's wishes and work to earn what you need instead of buying it. Though this is not an obligation, of course.

Radio Broadcaster II: But why not have a try when you are given the opportunity to experience a new and better lifestyle? Trust me, you won't be disappointed.

???: Heh heh.

???: Where should I start, dear readers?

???: Rayashki is like a sparkling gem embedded into the permafrost. And above flies an eye-catching banner. Perhaps it will draw even more attention in the future.

???: Through the past decades, the citizens there have been trying to achieve something different for themselves.

???: A great cause which may take the work of generations to achieve.

???: But now they are no longer a nameless town in the far north, nor is their dream a passing fad bound to be forgotten.

???: I sincerely hope all of us will be able to witness its history and its future.

???: That's why I knew I must write down this story. In the hopes that their dream will remain in your heart forever.

8#2

Damp Paperslip

小径

Lost Export Plan Found at Port

Raw Coal:

Commonly used as a fuel for combustion. Suitable for heating and power generation. High priority for direct export (but can cause resource waste and air pollution).

Coal Gasification:

Can be converted into clean fuel gas for synthesis (related technology and facilities are expensive – consider collaborative production methods).

Coal Ash:

Produced from boiler combustion. Can be recycled for use in road construction. No need for export.

Coking Coal:

Important material for iron smelting (perhaps the ironworks could be rebuilt?).

In addition: It is reported that there is technology to produce refined coal after it is washed, and there is a high demand for refined coal in the south. Should be prioritized.

What is the source of this report? Who could have predicted that we would uncover a coal mine, or that we had been to the south?

—Comrade Evgeni listed more than a dozen common uses and export directions for energy in his letter, and we found one that we could use.

Narrow Path

小径

An advertisement from the ads page of Wall Street Journal.

> Come to C.C Critter Pawnshop to make extra money!
> TEL: 847-6861XXX
>
> Are the cunning, ubiquitous critters annoying you again? Don't take that as bad news, because if you have a critter, you just found yourself enough money to pay your rent! We offer the best, the most precise, and the most honest pricing options you'll ever find! Our shop will buy any critters from the cheapest Carbuncles to the expensive yet delicious Rubberados that keep diners bouncing about! C.C swears on its name that every critter we buy will be treated like a family in compliance with internationally recognized standards of humane treatment!

Essential Reading

小径

Miners' Code and Appendix

> Part One: Standard Training
>
> 1. Must complete safety knowledge training and pass a test before working.
>
> 2. Must be familiar with the site survey and operating procedures for the appropriate type of work.
>
> ....
>
> 9. Anyone under the age of 16 or over the age of 60 is absolutely prohibited from entering the mine.
>
> Part Two: Practical Operations
>
> 1. Arrive at the site on time for shift changes.
>
> 2. Check the safety of the site, the quantity and quality of materials, and remove any obstructions that may impede operations.
>
> ....
>
> 9. Prepare a written record of the mine's safety conditions prior to shift changes, and regularly update and review this record.
>
> Part Three: Safety Instructions
>
> 1. Must start engines according to standard procedures and perform reverse checks to ensure equipment reliability.
>
> 2. If abnormalities occur while operating winches, locomotives, or pickup vehicles, stop and investigate immediately.
>
> 3. Bring all necessary tools with you before entering the mine. Sharp tools must be carried in protective covers.
>
> ...
>
> 19. Fill out the logbook carefully and check it regularly.

Appendix - Index of Self-Manufacturable Components at the Factory

...

17. Cross Slides (process temporarily missing)

Comrade Evgeni extracted the method from the book. We have enough raw materials, approved for production. —I. I. Novikov

It's hard to make, but let's try anyway. —Bo. F. Braginskaya

Hey, Tomorrow!

小径

Kiril, it's time to get back to work! Please remind Bogina to come down from the forklift and stop playing Sudoku. We have to deliver the wood for reinforcing the mine roof by tonight.

Oh, Knut! What brings you here? It's not yet time for the shift change.

I'm not here for the shift change. I'm actually just dropping off some parts and a toolbox we found. Take a look, it's fully stocked.

I couldn't help but notice Comrade Kiril standing off to the side, spinning in circles. It almost made me dizzy when I first arrived.

He's been acting like this since the lunch break started, while Bogina is engrossed in her usual game. I wonder what's going on with Kiril ...

Illia, you haven't had the chance to read Comrade Evgeni's letter, so you don't know.

...

Looking at the stains on my hands from the coal dust, I can't help but think of his letter again. I find myself pacing back and forth, imagining how my comrades will lay me to rest when my time comes. It would be a great honor, but also ...

I can't help but feel that Comrade Evgeni deserved a different fate than this.

He did not deserve to end his journey in this place.

Kiril ...

Comrade Knut was the first to find the letter. Later we all took turns touching it, like passing around a flag, remember?

You shouldn't talk like that to Illia, and you shouldn't think like that about comrade Evgeni.

But you said the same thing earlier, Bogina.

Yes, I said that. But I also said—

"Comrade Evgeni ended his journey here, but we must go on."

With only one square left to fill in the Sudoku, it's clear that this is the only way to go.

"Keep moving forward, to a better tomorrow."

This is not the end of our journey, Comrade Kiril.

Right ... I may not be good with words, but I wholeheartedly agree with comrade Bogina.

This must have been Comrade Evgeni's true wish.

Hey, Tomorrow!

Snow

小径

Snow and Other Possibilities

To the town, she is a familiar figure. But to herself, everything is so drastically different.

She's used to walking in the snow. The poplar fluff floating through Moscow's streets reminds her of Rayashki; it's like snow, but it doesn't make her cheeks turn red or her hands and feet cold; it doesn't melt on the skin, nor can it hide anything. Canned goods, even sausages and fresh meat, are available in stores, and one doesn't have to count the days just to exchange for everyday items ... The first time she made soup in her new home, it felt surreal. Another vivid memory was when she got off the train, holding her child's hand in fear. Outside the small town, in Moscow, there were so many people, all seemingly full of hope.

But she boarded the train back to Rayashki anyway.

Rayashki had changed, too. There were faces in the town she didn't recognize, and the statue in the center of the square had changed. The school was still the same, and the children played games in the small playground. The townspeople's greetings were a bit awkward; no one mentioned her hasty departure as if it was not important, as if anyone could leave at any time and also return whenever they wanted.

Snow fell on her hair and collar, turning her fingers and nose red—this was real snow.

The Path Ahead

小径

It's good to see you again, Comrade Ulyana. I heard that you have returned.

Did you get a chance to go to see the children? They've been going on about you for so long.

It's been a while since I've been back to this town. How are the little ones doing? With you watching over them, I'm sure they're doing fine. You've always been such a caring teacher.

But there is only so much that one person can do. It would be great to have another comrade to lend a hand.

So, will you stay this time, Comrade Ulyana?

Right. I wanted to talk to you about that ...

We can take our time to talk, no need to rush. By the way, did little Vasya come with you?

Now that our supplies are fully stocked, we can take the children to the square tomorrow for some sketching ...

It's just me this time, Comrade Vila.

...

Back in Moscow, my thoughts kept returning to Rayashki. Those who have chosen to stay here are incredibly determined and tenacious. They are genuinely sincere and kind, but they are very stubborn in their beliefs. Does that make any sense?

In Moscow, you don't have to worry about cold temperatures or lack of resources. If children need pencils, they can simply go to the nearest store and buy them.

That sounds like a dream come true! We're doing everything we can to make Rayashki just that.

It was really beautiful, but when I sat next to Vasya's bed, when he was fighting his asthma, with the poplar fuzz in the air ... And then children's gravestones and coffins, so tiny and fragile, almost like toys ... I could hardly believe they were real.

I clung to the hope that life would get better in Moscow. I believed that if I just endured and persevered a little longer, things would turn around.

But that was not the way it turned out.

My sincerest condolences, Comrade Ulyana.

It's alright, I brought it up myself. When I was in the house in Moscow, I couldn't stop crying. But eventually I realized that I had to pull myself together and do something.

Is it still possible for me to reunite with everyone? Looking back, I regret leaving in such a selfish manner.

The future is unknown and unpredictable. All we can do is take one step at a time on the path that lies ahead of us.

You will always have the ability to move forward on this path, with all of us.

The Path Ahead

Welcome Home!

小径

Don't all crowd around us at once, kids. Give us some space so that Miss Ulyana, your teacher, can greet you, okay?

Hooray! We're super happy you're teaching again, Miss Ulyana! Tee-hee!

Miss Ulyana! There are soo many new things in town that I can't wait to show you!

Me too! I know this town like the back of my hand, and I've got a sneaky shortcut to the mine to show you!

Of course, my little bears, my patient little comrades.

Here. I received this as a gift from the square, and I want to share it with you. Vila always tells us to share with others.

What a beautiful sunflower. Thank you, Avgust. Say, you seem much happier now.

I notice that my mom and everyone else around me are smiling, so I can't help but smile too.

You're smiling too, Ulyana.

Haha, yes. I, I really missed you all.

Aw, don't rub your eyes with your hands, kids. Here's some handkerchiefs for you ...

It took you kids a long time to come up with that welcome. Don't forget to actually say it to Miss Ulyana.

—Welcome home, Miss Ulyana!

...!

The welcome and the celebration, all arranged on the same day ... Rayashki is slowly gaining momentum again, but there's still so much to do. I hope you don't mind.

No, not at all. How can I be of help? Just let me know.

Would you mind taking care of the children for a while? I have to go check on the port soon, and some friends from the Foundation are coming over for their regular lectures. Please make sure they are held to the same standards as our agreement. And finally ...

Welcome home, Comrade Ulyana!

Welcome Home!

Toward the Distance

小径

I've finished folding it, Comrade Pyotr. It's time to make our paper planes fly. Can you move a little? Just a bit!

Alright! Let's see whose plane can fly the farthest!

Three, two, one!

The swallow dives into the snow pile. Pyotr wins.

He hasn't flown his yet, Comrade Avgust, maybe ...

Hey, Pasono, are you not going to play with us?

... I've been thinking about what Miss Vila said.

Are you scared? Don't you want to go out and see? After all, our parents agreed, and adults always know better than we do.

I'm not scared! But... Miss Vila said she will not go with us, neither will Miss Ulyana.

Vila has a lot to do. After the slow turtles left, many new friends came to town. Vila wants to talk to them.

I don't think we need to worry so much. The teachers have allowed these friends of the Foundation to attend our classes, play with us, and take notes ...

They don't seem like bad people. If they were bad, Miss Vila would shoo them away.

That's right, Pasono! Even Avgust isn't as anxious as you are!

I'm not nervous, I just want to learn how to transform things. Like turning a sunflower into a towering soldier or a bear with round ears ...

We could turn snowmen into us to keep Vila company. Mom always said that when we miss her, we should build a snowman.

—And Vila will definitely miss us when we're gone.

Yes, we should leave a gift for Miss Vila! Let's go make some snowmen!

Alright!

Yes, let's find the prettiest twigs to decorate them with!

Let's go, everyone. Split up to find materials and come back as quickly as we can!

Toward the Distance

Twig Collecting Initiative

小径

An advertisement from the ads page of Wall Street Journal.

> Come to C.C Critter Pawnshop to make extra money!
> TEL: 847-6861XXX
>
> Are the cunning, ubiquitous critters annoying you again? Don't take that as bad news, because if you have a critter, you just found yourself enough money to pay your rent! We offer the best, the most precise, and the most honest pricing options you'll ever find! Our shop will buy any critters from the cheapest Carbuncles to the expensive yet delicious Rubberados that keep diners bouncing about! C.C swears on its name that every critter we buy will be treated like a family in compliance with internationally recognized standards of humane treatment!

Children's Creation

小径

Circle Dance

> Snowmen of various sizes were arranged in a circle on the playground, and the children lovingly linked their twig arms together so that the snow friends were holding hands. Each child focused on decorating their little creation, staying close together, and when one arm brushed another's shoulder, there was a cheerful laugh.
>
> The little girl on the far left lowered her head, her braids curled up like haystacks in the sun. She carefully placed sunflower petals on her snowman's head. Nearby, two boys were trying to make their snowman's chubby body wider and sturdier so it would last longer and Ms. Vila could greet them more often.
>
> The little boy's snowman was a bear. It was only through his explanation that the head and paws of the arctic fox could be seen on its back. Foxes don't usually have long ears like rabbits, but he gave it those in order to hear his mother's footsteps, Vila's footsteps, and his friends' footsteps. Finally, he carefully placed the mined ore on the fox's chest, just as he wore the beautiful stone his father had left him.
>
> "Okay, my frosty comrades! You can all stay here and do the circle dance with Ms. Vila. Remember, no running around or making a ruckus; just listen to her instructions ..."

The Workers

小径

Caring Crowd

> Among the long tables sits a group of people.
>
> The one in the middle maintains her usual politeness and friendly smile. If you weren't looking at how her hands are resting uncertainly on the table, you'd miss the emotion beyond the politeness. Yes, this young scholar is stunned that the theory she has been focusing on is back in the spotlight. After being relegated to the pile of old papers in most places outside, it has found a place in Rayashki.
>
> As for the people around her, most are still wearing their work clothes, with coal dust clinging to their collars and pant legs. They are aware of this and keep their distance from the scholar until she reaches out to them. This group of makeshift teachers and students shake hands, determined to spend time understanding a fading discipline. Those most dedicated to the work are also the most serious pragmatists. The study of ley lines has played such an important role in the rebuilding of the town! When the scholar first entered the research institute, this is what she had hoped for. Is the study of ley lines omnipotent? No. But it may eventually bring about change.
>
> Perhaps it will be the moment the coal mine was discovered, or perhaps it is this moment.

Unexpected Scenario

小径

An advertisement from the ads page of Wall Street Journal.

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>
> Are the cunning, ubiquitous critters annoying you again? Don't take that as bad news, because if you have a critter, you just found yourself enough money to pay your rent! We offer the best, the most precise, and the most honest pricing options you'll ever find! Our shop will buy any critters from the cheapest Carbuncles to the expensive yet delicious Rubberados that keep diners bouncing about! C.C swears on its name that every critter we buy will be treated like a family in compliance with internationally recognized standards of humane treatment!

To the Horizon Line

小径

Wow. I'm getting a little nervous.

There are a lot of new faces here, quite unexpected. Well, hopefully a midday vodka will calm my nerves.

May I have your attention, please? Comrades and visitors, welcome to today's lecture on the study of ley lines.

I am Windsong, your speaker for today.

Now, I will present some practical examples on how the Study of Ley Lines can be applied to the mineral development in Rayashki ...

...

This is undoubtedly beneficial to our research. Who cares about other people's opinions? Personally, I find Ley Lines very useful and relevant.

We definitely need to try this out and tell Ms. Lucy about it. I have no doubt she would be intrigued by this type of presentation ...

I'll take thorough notes. I'll be prepared in case there's a Q&A session later.

Hello, there!

Uh? Oh. Hello, ma'am.

If you need a seat closer to the front, I can take you to the visitor's seats over there.

No thank you, I'm not a typical guest like them. I'm here as a researcher.

Is there somewhere I can hear more clearly? Does Ms. Windsong have any other business to attend to? I have a list of questions written down, such as methods for identifying lines ...

There will be a Q&A session after the presentation. Follow me and we'll see if there's a better location for you that's closer and more spacious.

...

Phew, I really need a drink. This is as tiring as any physical labor.

I hope the Q&A session won't be met with dead silence. Just in case, I have prepared a couple of basic talking points ...

Comrade Windsong, here.

Perfect. This glass of water couldn't have come at a better time.

The lecture went smoothly, and I still have time to make it to today's performance. As I promised to Avgust and the others, I have a little trick with ley lines that will surely amaze them.

The Study of Ley Lines is much more than just a little trick, Comrade Windsong. We all know this to be true.

The woman from Laplace has technical inquiries for you. You might want to finish your drink, I have a feeling she has quite a few questions lined up.

She can ask all she wants about the subject. The truth is, I'll be researching Ley Lines for a long time to come.

What are your thoughts on this lecture? I welcome constructive criticism, so feel free to share your honest opinions, Comrade Vila.

It brought back memories of a "line" I had seen before, although it's not exactly the same as your ley lines.

One morning I was floating on the surface of the water, admiring the distant shore. The horizon line seemed impossibly far away, with a soft glow radiating from it.

At that moment, I decided to go and see for myself. And so I arrived at Rayashki, my footprints leaving marks in the snow as I watched it transform into what it is today.

... It's remarkable how our dreams are gradually becoming a reality.

To the Horizon Line